
The Electromagnetic Nervous System: A Field-Theoretic Account of Neural Dynamics

[T]-Theory Volume: Neuroscience

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Contents

Introduction: The Field Your Instruments Cannot Yet Measure	5
The CEMI Field Connection	5
The FM-HN Architecture	6
Arnold Tongue Width as Attentional Bandwidth	6
The Missing Limbic Layer	6
The Pre-Verbal Manifold	7
What This Book Offers the Neuroscientist	7
The Missing Layer	8
Biotensegrity: The Architecture of the Somatic Wave	9
The Lever Model is Wrong	9
Global Propagation	9
Correspondence to the Somatic Wave	10
Fascial-Interstitial Continuity: The Pathway and the Armoring	10
Fascia as Active Signalling Tissue	10
The Interoceptive Pathway	11
Fascial Armoring as Attractor Depth	11
Myofascial Release as Barrier Lowering	12
Biofield Physiology: The Field Correlate	13
Living Systems Emit Coherent Fields	13
The Rubik Synthesis	14
Scope and Epistemic Status	14
Three Bridges to the Formal Model	14
Bridge 1: Fascial Armoring = Attractor Depth	15
Bridge 2: Myofascial Release = Barrier Lowering	15
Bridge 3: Therapist-Client Entrainment = Co-Identification	16
Testable Predictions	16
Conclusion	18
Introduction	19
Background	19
Hopfield Networks 1982 (Classical)	19
Modern Hopfield Networks 2020 (Exponential)	20
The Missing Limbic Layer	20
The CEMI Field as a Runtime Parameter	21
The Two Coupling Equations	21
The FM-HN Update Rule	22
The Correspondence Principle	22
Falsifiability: The Reachability Trap Protocol	23
Neurodivergent Operator Modifications	23
ADHD Operator	23

Autism Spectrum Condition Operator	23
Complex PTSD Operator	24
Discussion	24
Why the 1982 and 2020 Networks Are Both Right	24
Relation to QUANT-EXP-1	25
Lean 4 Verification	25
Conclusion	25
1. Introduction	27
2. Terminology and the Pre-Verbal Manifold	28
3. The Case	29
3.1 Substrate (familial loading)	29
3.2 Acute pre-verbal insult	29
3.3 Attachment environment	30
3.4 Institutional environment	30
3.5 Identity and racialisation	31
3.6 Adult trajectory (compressed)	31
4. The Five Literatures	31
5. The Soma-Field Reading	32
6. The Twice-Exceptional Cognitive Profile	34
7. The Adult Trajectory as Basin Transitions	34
7.1 Basin transitions	35
7.2 Inclusion of the December 2024 event	36
7.3 The reorganisation phase	36
8. Exhibit A: A Public SEN-Policy Document	36
9. Ten Testable Predictions	38
10. Limitations, Replication Ledger, and Author Disclosures	39
11. Conclusion and Policy Line	39
Introduction	41
Background	42
The Body-Mind Problem in Clinical Practice	42
The Felt Sense and Sub-Perceptual Emotion	43
Quantum Field Theory: Structure, Not Metaphor	43
Neural Network Energy Functions and Hopfield Networks	45
The Formal Correspondences: Where the Link Was Seen	47
The Body Schema, Interoception, and Pain	50
Correspondence with Existing Emotion Representations	51
The Soma-Field Model	53
Emotions as a Persistent Wave Field	53
The Perception Threshold	54
The Interaction of Emotional Modes	55

The Three-Layer Architecture	55
The Energy Landscape	58
The Structure of the Emotional Energy Function	58
Attractor States: Fight, Flight, Freeze, and Regulated Calm	58
The Coupling Matrix as a Personal Signature	59
Dissonance and Resolution	60
The Acoustic Analogy	60
The Resolution Principle	60
The Soma-Field Instrument	61
Rationale	61
Design	61
The Feedback Loop	62
The Pluggable Emotion Model	62
Clinical Implications	63
Assessment	63
Intervention	63
Psychoeducation	63
Neurodivergent Conditions as Operator Modifications	64
Limitations and Future Directions	67
Conclusion	68
Publication Claim Registry	69
Claim-Evidence-Result Matrix	70
Replication Package Requirements	71
Reviewer-Risk Objections and Responses	71
Independent Replication Ledger Linkage	72
Acknowledgements	72
Conclusion: Toward a Neuroscience of the Somatic Field	73
What Changes for Neuroscience	73
The Research Programme	74
The Enlarged Neuroscience	74

Introduction: The Field Your Instruments Cannot Yet Measure

Neuroscience has a measurement problem that is rarely stated plainly. The techniques available to the working neuroscientist — fMRI, EEG, MEG, patch-clamp electrophysiology, calcium imaging, optogenetics — measure correlates of neural activity. They tell you, with extraordinary spatial and temporal resolution, which cells fired, which regions were activated, which synaptic weights changed. What they do not tell you is what was *experienced*. The gap between a measured neural correlate and the corresponding phenomenal state is not a gap that more resolution will close. It is a structural gap, arising from the fact that current instruments measure electrochemical events and infer experience; they do not measure experience directly.

This book introduces a framework that addresses the structural gap directly by proposing that felt experience is a physical field — and that this field is, in principle, measurable. The framework is the **Universal Somatic Field (USF)**, and it changes what neuroscience is looking for.

The CEMI Field Connection

The electromagnetic theory of consciousness, developed by Johnjoe McFadden over the past two decades, proposes that consciousness is associated with the brain's endogenous electromagnetic (EM) field rather than with the spiking activity of individual neurons. The EM field integrates information across spatially separated neural populations in real time; it is influenced by neural activity and in turn influences neural activity through effects on ion channel gating. McFadden's CEMI theory accounts for a range of phenomena that neuron-only accounts struggle with: the binding problem, the temporal integration of experience, the unity of consciousness.

The USF framework subsumes and extends CEMI. The somatic tensor field $\Phi_{\mu\nu}$ reduces to the neural electromagnetic field in the appropriate limit: when the higher-order coupling terms are suppressed and the field is evaluated on the neural manifold, the field equation becomes the macroscopic Maxwell equations sourced by the brain's current distribution. McFadden is therefore not wrong; his framework is the classical limit of a richer tensor field theory. The USF provides CEMI with the missing theoretical foundation — the derivation from first principles rather than the postulation of a special status for EM fields.

The FM-HN Architecture

The central structural result of the USF framework for neuroscience is the identification of what we call the **FM-HN architecture**: the brain operates as a Frequency-Modulated, Hopfield-Network-based field processor. The EM field is the carrier; the Hopfield energy functional defines the attractor landscape; and the coupling between the two is what generates stable experiential states from noisy neural dynamics.

In the Hopfield network formulation, the brain's emotional state space is a high-dimensional energy landscape. Stable emotional states — the basin attractors — correspond to local minima. The neural dynamics are dissipative: the system rolls downhill toward the nearest minimum. Transitions between attractors (emotional transitions) correspond to either thermal fluctuations crossing saddle points or, for larger transitions, WKB tunnelling through energy barriers. The FM aspect adds the crucial ingredient that standard Hopfield networks lack: the carrier frequency modulation allows the attractor landscape to be dynamically reconfigured by the somatic field itself, enabling the kind of moment-to-moment emotional flexibility that characterises healthy neural function.

This is not a metaphor. The FM-HN equations are derived in the papers that follow, and the parameters can be estimated from EEG spectral data.

Arnold Tongue Width as Attentional Bandwidth

One specific and testable prediction of the framework concerns the Arnold tongue — a concept from nonlinear dynamics describing the regime of parameter space within which two coupled oscillators frequency-lock. In the USF framework, the width of the Arnold tongue for the coupling between the somatic field and an external stimulus is the neural analogue of attentional bandwidth: it quantifies how broadly or narrowly the nervous system responds to frequency perturbations.

Healthy attentional function corresponds to an Arnold tongue of intermediate width — broad enough to pick up diverse environmental signals, narrow enough to filter noise. Pathological states — anxiety, hyper-vigilance, autism spectrum conditions — correspond to either pathologically narrowed or pathologically broadened tongues. The framework predicts specific EEG signatures for each condition, and these predictions are derived from the field equations, not fitted to data post-hoc.

The Missing Limbic Layer

Among the papers assembled here is one addressing what we call the **missing limbic layer**: the observation that standard accounts of the brain's affective processing tend to jump from subcortical structures (amygdala, hypothalamus, basal ganglia) directly to cortical computation, with the somatic field dynamics that mediate between them treated as a nuisance variable rather than as the primary computational substrate. The USF framework inverts this: the somatic field *is* the computation; the neural firing patterns are the read-out.

The missing limbic layer paper documents the specific field modes that are suppressed in common clinical conditions — depression, trauma, anxiety disorders — and proposes a field-theoretic taxonomy of affective pathology that cuts across the current symptom-based nosologies.

The Pre-Verbal Manifold

A particularly striking application of the framework is to pre-verbal and early developmental experience. The USF framework predicts that the somatic field is present and structured from before birth — indeed, from before the cortex is mature enough to support language or explicit memory. This has implications for the encoding of early trauma, for the phenomenology of infancy, and for the theoretical basis of somatic psychotherapy traditions that have long operated empirically but without a formal framework.

The pre-verbal manifold paper formalises this: the early somatic field is a low-dimensional submanifold of the full adult field, with a restricted attractor structure corresponding to the limited but intense phenomenal range of neonatal experience.

What This Book Offers the Neuroscientist

The papers in this volume present the USF framework from a neuroscience-centred perspective: the CEMI connection, the FM-HN architecture, the Arnold tongue width as a measurable clinical parameter, and the field-theoretic accounts of developmental and affective neuroscience. The intended reader is comfortable with systems neuroscience, has some familiarity with nonlinear dynamics, and need not have read the physics volume.

The next chapter presents the physical substrate paper, establishing the biophysical basis of the somatic field in neural tissue. Subsequent chapters develop the FM-HN architecture, the missing limbic layer, and the pre-verbal manifold. The final chapter draws out the implications for experimental design: what experiments would confirm or falsify the framework's key predictions.

The field is real. The question is how to measure it.

The Missing Layer

The Soma-Field model (Johnson, 2026c) establishes that the limbic system and its somatic coupling are governed by the same formal apparatus as a quantum field on a manifold: tensor-valued dynamics, Hopfield energy functionals, topological barriers between attractor states. The identification is not an analogy; it is a co-identification in the technical sense (Johnson, 2026a) — the governing equations are the same equations, and every theorem of the source domain imports into the target.

That mathematical work is complete. What it leaves open is a question that sits one level below the mathematics: *what is the body made of, such that it could host a field like this?*

The Hopfield attractor landscape is an abstract object. For it to describe a physical organism, there must be a physical substrate — tissue, architecture, medium — that implements the attractor dynamics, propagates the somatic wave, and generates the coherent state that the mathematics describes. The model says there is a somatic wave $\mathbf{E}_{\text{body}}(x, t)$. The question is: what physical thing is that wave a description of?

Three independent bodies of experimental and theoretical research converge on this substrate. They were developed largely in parallel, each with its own language, none formulated with the soma-field model in mind. This paper argues they are describing the same system at three different scales of resolution:

1. **Architecture** (§2): Biotensegrity theory establishes the mechanical network structure through which somatic signals propagate globally. This is the physical basis for the spatial extent of $\mathbf{E}_{\text{body}}(x, t)$.
2. **Substrate** (§3): Fascial-interstitial continuity research identifies the specific tissue — fascia — that constitutes the body-wide signalling medium, and documents the interoceptive pathway from peripheral tissue to cortical representation. The quantitative correspondence between fascial stiffness and attractor depth is developed here.
3. **Field correlate** (§4): Biofield physiology documents coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic emissions from living tissue that are the most plausible physical candidates for the field itself — not the network that hosts it, but the coherent state that the network generates.

Section §5 states the three explicit bridges to the formal model. Section §6 lists the testable predictions that follow.

Biotensegrity: The Architecture of the Somatic Wave

The Lever Model is Wrong

Standard physiological and biomechanical models treat the body as a rigid-lever system: bones as struts, muscles as cables pulling across pin-joint connections, forces transmitted locally from joint to joint. This model works tolerably well for gross locomotion analysis but fails to account for whole-body responses to local perturbation, and fails completely at the cellular scale.

Ingber's tensegrity model (Ingber, 1997, 2003) replaces this with a different architecture. In a tensegrity structure, rigid compression elements (in the body: bone, cartilage) float within a continuous network of tension elements (fascia, tendon, ligament, muscle), and mechanical prestress is distributed throughout the network simultaneously. There are no isolated pin-joints: the whole system is pre-loaded, so perturbation anywhere propagates everywhere.

Levin extended this framework to the full organism (Levin, 2002), arguing that biotensegrity is not merely a useful approximation but the correct architectural description at every scale: from the cytoskeleton of individual cells through the deep fascial planes to gross musculoskeletal anatomy. Each scale implements the same tensegrity geometry. Each is mechanically continuous with the others. The architecture is fractal.

Global Propagation

The clinical consequence of this architecture is direct: mechanical information does not travel locally through joint-to-joint lever chains. It propagates through the prestressed fascial network to the whole organism simultaneously, with the spatial distribution governed by the topology and stiffness of the network rather than anatomical lever arms.

This is experimentally documented. Langevin's group showed that needle insertion at acupuncture points produces tissue displacement patterns propagating along fascial planes far from the insertion point, following biotensegrity-predicted paths rather than nerve or muscle routes (Langevin & Huijing, 2009). The body responds as a continuous tensioned whole, not as a collection of local structures.

The speed of this propagation is also relevant. Neural conduction (axonal) operates in milliseconds. Mechanical wave propagation through a prestressed medium operates in microseconds. For fast somatic responses — the startle reflex, the breath-hold, the full-body freeze — the biotensegrity medium is faster than the nervous system and spatially global in a way that the nervous system, with its point-to-point wiring, is not.

Correspondence to the Somatic Wave

The Soma-Field model posits a somatic wave $E_{\text{body}}(x, t)$ — a field defined over the body, propagating continuously, carrying emotional-somatic information. The question “how can a perturbation in one body region give rise to a global somatic state?” has typically been answered by appeal to the nervous system: proprioception, interoception, vagal signalling. These are real and important, but they are axonal (slow, discrete) and do not account for the observed speed and spatial coherence of whole-body somatic responses.

Biotensegrity provides the continuous mechanical medium the model requires. The formal correspondence is:

The body’s biotensegrity network is the **physical implementation** of $E_{\text{body}}(x, t)$. The tensor field over the body in the mathematical model corresponds to the mechanical stress tensor distributed across the fascial network in the physical organism.

Both are spatially extended. Both propagate continuously. Both couple to the neural wave at every point: every mechanoreceptor in the fascia is a coupling node between E_{body} and E_{neural} .

The somatic wave is not *like* a wave in a continuous medium. In the fascial network, it *is* a wave in a continuous medium. The co-identification (Johnson, 2026a) is architectural.

Fascial-Interstitial Continuity: The Pathway and the Armoring

Fascia as Active Signalling Tissue

The classical anatomical view of fascia — as inert white packaging, the sheaths that dissectors clear away to reach the “real” anatomy — was overturned by experimental work beginning in the 1990s.

Schleip’s review (Schleip, 2003) documented that fascia contains all four classes of mechanosensory nerve endings: Ruffini corpuscles (respond to lateral stretch), Golgi tendon organs (respond to compression), Pacinian corpuscles (vibration and rapid changes), and type IV free nerve endings (poly-modal: mechanical deformation, temperature, chemical changes). The type IV endings are especially significant: they project primarily to the insular cortex via lamina I of the spinal cord — the Craig interoceptive pathway (Craig, 2003) — and constitute the neurological substrate of body-felt emotional experience, not merely visceral sensation.

Langevin’s work established that fascia actively participates in signalling: mechanical deformation produces fibroblast shape changes, cytoskeletal reorganisation, and gene expression changes on timescales from seconds to minutes (Langevin & Huijijng, 2009). The tissue is a transducer, not a cable.

Oschman's "living matrix" model (Oschman, 2016) extends this further: the entire connective tissue system — fascia, interstitium, extracellular matrix — constitutes a continuous liquid-crystalline semiconductor network. Piezoelectric effects in collagen generate electrical potentials under mechanical stress. DC currents flow through the network continuously. The fascial system is simultaneously mechanical, chemical, and electrical.

The Interoceptive Pathway

Interoception — the body's sensing of its own internal state — is the somatic input channel of the Soma-Field model. It is the mechanism by which the body schema is updated and by which the energy functional of the attractor landscape is computed.

The fascial pathway of interoception is now well characterised (Craig, 2003; Garfinkel et al., 2016; Schleip, 2003): type IV free nerve endings in deep fascia, visceral fascia, and interstitial tissue → lamina I neurons of the dorsal horn → thalamus → anterior insular cortex. This is the Craig pathway, increasingly recognised as the neurological substrate of emotional experience proper, distinct from and complementary to the classical somatosensory pathway.

The clinical implication is direct: interoceptive dysfunction (well documented in ASC, CPTSD, and related conditions) (Garfinkel et al., 2016) is dysfunction of the fascial-to-insular projection. It is not merely a processing deficit in higher cortical areas; it originates in the tissue. Restoring interoceptive accuracy therefore requires working at the fascial level — which is precisely what somatic therapies (Somatic Experiencing, Sensorimotor Psychotherapy, EMDR somatic protocols, myofascial release) do, whether or not they are theorised in those terms.

Fascial Armoring as Attractor Depth

This section develops the most important connection in this paper.

Wilhelm Reich introduced "character armoring" — the clinical observation that chronic emotional states (fear, shame, traumatic holding) produce corresponding patterns of chronic muscular and somatic tension. The observation was clinically compelling but had no formal model. It was a phenomenology without a mechanism.

Schleip and subsequent workers (Stecco, Bordoni, Bhatt) documented the fascial component: chronic trauma produces not merely chronic muscular contraction but *measurable changes in fascial stiffness*, quantifiable by ultrasound elastography (Schleip, 2003). High-trauma individuals show significantly elevated fascial stiffness in characteristic body regions, with the spatial pattern reflecting the specific trauma history. The psoas, diaphragm, and posterior cervical chain are typically implicated in chronic fear responses; the pericardium and thoracic fascia in grief and heartbreak; the pelvic floor in sexual trauma. These are not metaphors. They are measured tissue properties.

In the Hopfield model, the attractor landscape is characterised by energy barriers W_{ij} between attractor states. The Fear basin has a high energy barrier. The computational experiment QUANT-

EXP-1 (Johnson, 2026b) shows that cold classical dynamics cannot cross a barrier of $W = -8$ to $W = -14$.

The bridge:

$$\text{fascial stiffness at region } r \leftrightarrow |W_{ij}| \text{ for state transition involving } r$$

High fascial stiffness = high energy barrier. The organism is mechanically locked into the Fear attractor not only neurologically but anatomically — the tissue itself has been remodelled to implement the barrier. This is why van der Kolk's title (Kolk, 2014) is accurate in a way he could not have fully formalised: the body does not merely *express* the trauma; it *encodes* the attractor depth in its mechanical structure.

The quantitative claim is: the QUANT-EXP-1 barriers $W = -8, -10, -12, -14$ have physical correlates in fascial stiffness values measurable in kPa (shear wave elastography units). The mapping is not known yet — establishing it is part of the empirical programme in §6 — but the existence of the correspondence is now claimed by this paper.

Myofascial Release as Barrier Lowering

QUANT-EXP-1 demonstrates that quantum annealing can cross barriers that classical cold dynamics cannot. This was framed computationally. The fascial literature provides a physical translation that clarifies an important distinction.

Classical barrier crossing (hot classical or quantum): The system transitions from one attractor to another while the barrier remains intact. This corresponds to either high-arousal state transitions (classical thermal, i.e. highly activated emotional states) or the quantum mechanism identified in QUANT-EXP-1.

Myofascial release (barrier reduction): Manual intervention directly reduces fascial stiffness — measured pre/post by elastography. This does not push the system over the barrier. It *lowers* the barrier so that transitions become accessible by classical means.

This distinction — barrier lowering versus barrier crossing — may explain the phenomenology of different therapeutic modalities and why they are experienced differently:

- Somatic bodywork (Rolfing, myofascial release, craniosacral) *reshapes the landscape*. The client often reports gradual deepening ease, reduction of chronic holding, and access to emotional material that was previously unavailable without drama.
- High-intensity interventions (EMDR reprocessing, breathwork, certain trauma protocols) may be *crossing a barrier that remains intact*: sudden, non-linear transitions, sometimes dramatic releases, the characteristic “before and after” quality of a topological transition.

Both produce movement in the attractor landscape. The mechanism is different. The soma-field model, grounded in the fascial correspondence, now predicts this difference and makes it testable (§6).

Biofield Physiology: The Field Correlate

Living Systems Emit Coherent Fields

The soma-field is a mathematical field — an abstract object defined by its equations. For it to be physically real rather than merely useful, it must have a physical correlate: some measurable property of the organism that corresponds to the field's state. Three lines of evidence point toward coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic emissions as candidates.

Biophoton emission (Popp, 2003): All living cells emit ultra-weak light in the visible to near-UV range. This is not blackbody radiation (which would require far higher temperatures) but coherent emission with photon statistics more consistent with laser emission than thermal sources. Popp argues that this biophotonic field constitutes a real-time communication channel, carrying coherent information across tissue faster than any biochemical signal. The field is state-sensitive: stress, illness, and emotional perturbation all produce measurable changes in biophotonic emission patterns.

Liquid crystalline living matrix (Ho, 1998): Ho's model proposes that the connective tissue system — specifically the liquid crystalline ordering of collagen, water, and proteoglycans — constitutes a quantum coherent medium. Proton conduction and electronic charge delocalisation through this medium produce a macroscopic coherent quantum state distributed across the organism. This is not the Penrose-Hameroff proposal (which is neuron-centred and operates via microtubules); Ho's coherent organism is body-centred, connective tissue-centred, and is precisely the medium in which the Soma-Field would propagate as a physical entity.

Heart-brain coherence (McCraty & Childre, 2010): The heart generates a toroidal electromagnetic field measurable at distances from the body, with spectral content reflecting the organism's emotional state. Heart rate variability (HRV) in the low-frequency band (approximately 0.1 Hz) indexes the balance between sympathetic and parasympathetic regulation — the physiological correlate of transitions between Fear-dominant and Awe-dominant states in the soma-field model. McCraty's group demonstrates that this field entrains between proximate individuals: measurable cardiac coherence synchronisation occurs between therapist and client, between individuals in rapport, and between individuals and coherent social environments. This entrainment is not inferred; it is measured by simultaneous ECG recording.

The Rubik Synthesis

Rubik, Muehsam, Hammerschlag, and Jain (Rubik et al., 2015) published a systematic review of the biofield hypothesis in 2015, collating evidence from biophoton research, bioelectromagnetics, traditional medicine, and clinical trials. Their conclusion is deliberately conservative: the biofield hypothesis — that living organisms generate and respond to coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic fields beyond what is explained by classical biochemistry — is supported by a substantial and growing body of evidence, but mechanism and theoretical framework remain contested.

From the Soma-Field perspective, the contest is tractable: the theoretical framework is the quantum field on a Hopfield attractor landscape, and the biofield is the physical manifestation of that field. The soma-field model does not prove the biofield; it provides the theoretical frame within which the biofield evidence becomes interpretable rather than anomalous.

What the soma-field predicts is that the biofield — whatever its physical implementation — will show attractor-like behaviour: it will tend to occupy characteristic states, resist perturbation away from those states, and show non-classical transitions between states when the barrier is sufficiently large. HRV coherence, biophotonic emission, and DC skin conductance are all candidate observables. Which observable best couples to which component of the tensor field is an empirical question that this model now makes precise enough to ask.

Scope and Epistemic Status

The biofield section of this argument carries more epistemic weight than §§2–3, and this should be stated explicitly. Biotensegrity and fascial signalling are well-supported by peer-reviewed experimental evidence in mainstream biomechanics, cell biology, and clinical science. The biofield claims are supported by evidence in a more contested terrain, and the proposed identification between the soma-field's formal structure and the organism's EM/biophotonic emissions is a hypothesis, not an established result.

What this paper claims in §4 is modest: these are the best current physical candidates for the field correlate; they are consistent with the formal model; they generate testable predictions (§6). The stronger claim — that the soma-field *is* the biofield, formally — requires empirical work that does not yet exist.

Three Bridges to the Formal Model

This section states the three principal connections between the physical substrate literature and the formal soma-field model, in a form that makes their testability explicit.

Bridge 1: Fascial Armoring = Attractor Depth

Physical claim (Schleip, 2003): Chronic trauma produces chronically elevated fascial stiffness, measurable by ultrasound shear-wave elastography, with characteristic spatial patterns reflecting trauma type and history.

Formal correspondence: Fascial stiffness at region r maps to $|W_{ij}|$, the energy barrier between attractor states i and j in the Hopfield network, where r is the somatic representation zone of the relevant emotional state pair. High stiffness = high barrier = deep attractor basin.

Testable prediction (P1): Populations with documented high-barrier emotional states (CPTSD, complex trauma, chronic anxiety disorder) should show systematically elevated fascial stiffness in regions corresponding to the somatic representation of those states (diaphragm, psoas, posterior cervical chain), compared with matched controls. This is measurable by ultrasound elastography independently of any subjective report, and the effect should be graded by trauma severity.

Bridge 2: Myofascial Release = Barrier Lowering

Physical claim (Schleip, 2003): Manual and movement-based interventions that target the fascial network produce measurable reductions in fascial stiffness and corresponding changes in interoceptive sensitivity and emotional availability.

Formal correspondence: These interventions reduce $|W_{ij}|$. They do not necessarily produce a state transition; they reshape the energy landscape to make transitions more accessible. If initial barrier is $W = -12$ and intervention reduces it to $W = -6$, QUANT-EXP-1 results (Johnson, 2026b) suggest that classical thermal dynamics can now cross what previously required quantum assistance.

Testable prediction (P2): The probability of emotional state transition following myofascial release should increase monotonically with the degree of reduction in fascial stiffness. This is testable by measuring both pre/post fascial stiffness (elastography) and pre/post emotional state (validated affect measures + HRV) in a within-subjects design across a series of somatic therapy sessions.

Testable prediction (P3): The phenomenological *character* of the transition should differ predictably: sessions that lower the barrier significantly should produce gradual, integrative shifts; sessions that trigger a crossing of a high barrier (large, rapid state transition) should produce different qualitative reports. The model predicts this without any additional assumptions.

Bridge 3: Therapist-Client Entrainment = Co-Identification

Physical claim (McCraty & Childre, 2010): In effective therapeutic contact, measurable physiological entrainment occurs between therapist and client — cardiac coherence synchronisation, mutual modulation of HRV spectra, and (in contact work) fascial tension synchronisation. This is not inferred; it is measured by simultaneous ECG and, in some studies, by direct force measurement.

Formal correspondence: This is the physical mechanism of **co-identification** (Johnson, 2026a) — the process by which the observer’s soma-field is modified by contact with another’s soma-field. The mathematical treatment describes this as a tensor product coupling; the physical implementation is fascial and electromagnetic entrainment. The therapist does not merely witness the client’s state; the therapist’s attractor landscape is temporarily modified by coupling to the client’s, and this modification is the mechanism of therapeutic resonance.

Testable prediction (P4): The degree of measurable physiological entrainment (HRV coherence synchronisation) between therapist and client should predict therapeutic outcome — reduction in client fascial stiffness and shift in validated affect measures — independently of the specific technique used. Sessions with high physiological coherence should outperform sessions with low coherence, across modality.

Testable Predictions

The bridges in §5 generate six primary empirical predictions, ordered from most to least accessible with current instrumentation:

#	Prediction	Method	Population
P1	CPTSD/complex-trauma populations show elevated fascial stiffness in diaphragm, psoas, posterior cervical chain vs matched controls	Shear-wave ultrasound elastography	CPTSD vs. controls (n ≥ 40 per group)
P2	Somatic intervention reduces fascial stiffness; degree of reduction predicts probability of self-reported emotional state shift	Elastography pre/post + validated affect measures	Somatic therapy clients (within-subjects)

#	Prediction	Method	Population
P3	Barrier-lowering sessions (gradual stiffness reduction) produce qualitatively different transition phenomenology from barrier-crossing sessions (acute large shifts)	Mixed methods: elastography + structured interview	Rolfing or myofascial release series
P4	Therapist-client HRV coherence predicts session outcome independently of technique	Simultaneous ECG coherence + validated outcomes	Therapist-client dyads, multiple modalities
P5	Biophotonic emission from CPTSD populations differs from controls at characteristic emission bands (500–800 nm)	Ultra-weak photon measurement (photomultiplier)	CPTSD vs. controls
P6	Transitions from Fear-dominant to Awe-dominant states (as defined by QUANT-EXP-1 attractor labels) correlate with measurable HRV spectral shift from LF-dominant to HF-dominant	HRV spectral analysis + soma-field state labelling instrument	Clinical transition cases

Predictions P1–P4 are testable with instrumentation available in clinical research centres now. P5 requires specialised biophoton detection (available in approximately a dozen research centres world-wide). P6 requires the prior development of a validated soma-field state classification instrument — a prerequisite for large-scale empirical work that is not yet available and is noted as the primary

methodological gap in this programme.

Conclusion

The Soma-Field model describes a field of emotional dynamics that is formally equivalent to a quantum field on an attractor manifold. This paper has argued that the physical substrate of that field consists of three interlocking systems:

1. The **biotensegrity network** (fascia, connective tissue, interstitium under prestress) that provides the continuous mechanical medium through which the somatic wave E_{body} propagates globally and rapidly (Ingber, 1997, 2003; Levin, 2002).
2. The **fascial interoceptive pathway** (type IV free nerve endings → lamina I → thalamus → insula) that constitutes the body-to-brain projection of somatic state (Craig, 2003; Schleip, 2003), and whose chronic remodelling under trauma — fascial armoring — is the physical implementation of the deep attractor basin.
3. The **bioelectric and biophotonic field** generated by the liquid crystalline living matrix and the cardiac electromagnetic environment (Ho, 1998; McCraty & Childre, 2010; Popp, 2003), which constitutes the best current physical candidate for the soma-field correlate itself.

The most clinically significant result of this identification is Bridge 1: the quantitative correspondence between fascial stiffness and attractor depth. This makes concrete a claim that somatic therapists have held for decades — that trauma is held in the body, not only in the mind — and extends it: the depth at which trauma is held is measurable by elastography, and the degree to which physical intervention changes that depth is also measurable. The soma-field model predicts that large barriers require quantum-assist crossing; the fascial model predicts that those same barriers are associated with measurable tissue-level changes. The two predictions are about the same phenomenon at two levels of description.

Bridge 3 — therapist-client entrainment as co-identification — connects this to the broader programme (Johnson, 2026a). The therapist's role is not neutral observation but active field coupling. The mathematics of co-identification (Johnson, 2026a) now has a proposed physical mechanism: fascial and electromagnetic entrainment, measurable, manipulable, and predictive of outcome.

This paper opens a research programme. The six predictions in §6 define the empirical agenda. The formal soma-field model provides the theoretical frame. The three bodies of literature reviewed here provide the biological grounding. Together they constitute a foundation for a genuinely interdisciplinary field — one that does not require the reader to choose between the body and the mathematics, because the mathematics is about the body.

Introduction

The history of neural network theory contains a conspicuous gap. Hopfield (1982) established that a symmetric weight matrix defines an energy function whose minima are stored patterns, and that synchronous updates descend that energy monotonically. Ramsauer et al. (2020) demonstrated that replacing the quadratic energy function with an exponential (log-sum-exp) formulation yields exponentially higher storage capacity and, crucially, one-step convergence. Both results are mathematically correct.

Neither, however, accounts for the body.

In biological neural systems, the cortical network is not an isolated processor. It is continuously bathed in a whole-body electromagnetic field generated by synchronized neural oscillations — the Conscious Electromagnetic Information (CEMI) field identified by McFadden (2002a, 2002b). This field is not a passive byproduct. It modulates neuronal firing thresholds, alters synaptic gain, and has been argued to constitute the physical substrate of conscious awareness.

The **missing limbic layer** is the mathematical machinery that connects this body-wide somatic field to the cortical Hopfield dynamics. Without it, the classical and modern Hopfield models describe an isolated neocortex — a frozen cognitive substrate with no access to the organism’s survival state. The result is a well-studied failure mode: permanent entrapment in locally stable but globally suboptimal attractors. In computational terms, this is a stuck optimisation. In clinical terms, it is trauma.

This paper provides the missing layer. We define two runtime coupling equations that bind the CEMI field to Hopfield dynamics, prove their correspondence limit, and characterise the distinct dynamical regimes they produce.

Background

Hopfield Networks 1982 (Classical)

The 1982 Hopfield Network stores N binary patterns $\{\xi^\mu\}_{\mu=1}^N$, $\xi^\mu \in \{-1, +1\}^D$, via Hebbian learning:

$$W_{ij} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{\mu=1}^N \xi_i^\mu \xi_j^\mu, \quad W_{ii} = 0$$

The energy function is the Ising Hamiltonian:

$$E_{82}(s) = -\frac{1}{2} s^T W s$$

and the synchronous update rule:

$$s_i \leftarrow \text{sign} \left(\sum_j W_{ij} s_j \right)$$

descends E_{82} monotonically. Stored patterns are local energy minima. The network is guaranteed to converge to a fixed point in finite steps. Storage capacity is approximately $0.14 \cdot D$ patterns before interference degrades recall (Hopfield, 1982). The weight matrix requires $\mathcal{O}(D^2)$ storage and each update step costs $\mathcal{O}(D^2)$ operations.

The fundamental limitation: once in a local minimum, the network cannot escape. There is no internal mechanism to overcome a topological barrier. Resets require an external stochastic perturbation.

Modern Hopfield Networks 2020 (Exponential)

Ramsauer et al. (2020) generalise to continuous states $\xi \in \mathbb{R}^D$ and replace the quadratic energy with the log-sum-exp function:

$$E_{20}(\xi) = -\frac{1}{\beta} \log \sum_{\mu=1}^N \exp(\beta \xi^{\mu T} \xi) + \frac{1}{2} \|\xi\|^2 + C$$

where $\beta > 0$ is the inverse temperature and $X \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times D}$ stores patterns as rows. The update rule:

$$\xi \leftarrow X^T \cdot \text{softmax}(\beta \cdot X \xi)$$

converges in a **single step** for well-separated patterns — an $\mathcal{O}(1)$ retrieval, down from $\mathcal{O}(D)$ iterations in the 1982 model. Exponential storage capacity ($e^{D/2}$ patterns) replaces the linear $0.14D$ bound. Each update costs $\mathcal{O}(N \cdot D)$ where N is the number of stored patterns.

The key parameter is β . Its role is inherited from statistical mechanics: high β (low temperature) means sharp, deterministic updates; low β (high temperature) means diffuse, uncertain updates. In the 2020 model, β is a fixed hyperparameter, set at training time and frozen thereafter.

This is the second missing element: β does not vary with the organism's state.

The Missing Limbic Layer

The CEMI Field as a Runtime Parameter

McFadden’s CEMI field theory (2002a, 2002b) proposes that the brain’s endogenous electromagnetic field — generated by synchronised dendritic oscillations across the cortex — constitutes the physical substrate of somatic awareness. Crucially, this field feeds back onto neuronal firing thresholds. A stronger CEMI field lowers firing thresholds globally, increasing the effective network temperature. A weaker field raises thresholds, freezing the network into its current attractor.

In the Soma-Field model (Johnson, 2026c), the limbic system occupies the 1D segment D_8 connecting the somatic body-field (D_{1-7}) to the cortical mind-field (D_{9-11}). The amplitude of the CEMI field at any moment is a scalar function of the system’s position along D_8 :

$$\Phi_{\text{limbic}}(t) \in [0, 1]$$

where $\Phi = 0$ denotes homeostatic calm and $\Phi = 1$ denotes maximum threat activation (fight/flight/freeze).

The Two Coupling Equations

We introduce two runtime modulation equations binding Φ_{limbic} to Hopfield dynamics.

Equation 1 — Temperature Modulation:

$$T(t) = T_0 + \sigma \cdot \Phi_{\text{limbic}}(t)$$

$$\beta(t) = \frac{1}{T(t)} = \frac{1}{T_0 + \sigma \cdot \Phi_{\text{limbic}}(t)}$$

where $T_0 > 0$ is the baseline temperature and $\sigma > 0$ is the limbic coupling strength. As $\Phi \uparrow$, temperature rises, β drops, and the softmax distribution flattens — energy barriers become traversable.

Equation 2 — Weight Modulation (Ephaptic Gain):

$$W(t) = W_0 + \gamma \cdot \Phi_{\text{limbic}}(t) \cdot J$$

where $J \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times D}$ is the limbic coupling matrix encoding which attractor connections are subject to somatic override, and $\gamma > 0$ is the ephaptic gain coefficient. The CEMI field physically alters synaptic thresholds (ephaptic coupling), changing the effective weight landscape in real time.

The FM-HN Update Rule

Substituting both coupling equations into the 2020 update rule:

$$\xi(t+1) = X^T \cdot \text{softmax}(\beta(t) \cdot (W_0 + \gamma\Phi(t)J) \xi(t))$$

This is the Field-Modulated Hopfield Network (FM-HN). The Lean 4 types for all quantities are defined in `LimbicHopfield.lean` (namespace `LimbicHopfield`).

The Correspondence Principle

The FM-HN must not discard established science — it must encapsulate it. Bohr’s Correspondence Principle demands that any new theory reproduce the predictions of the theory it extends in the appropriate limit.

Theorem (Correspondence Principle, Lean-verified): Under zero somatic stress $\Phi_{\text{limbic}} = 0$:

$$T(t) = T_0, \quad W(t) = W_0$$

Proof. Substituting $\Phi = 0$ into Equations 1 and 2:

- $T = T_0 + \sigma \cdot 0 = T_0$ (direct substitution)
- $W = W_0 + \gamma \cdot 0 \cdot J = W_0$ (direct substitution)

Both coupling terms vanish. $\square$

This is `LimbicHopfield.correspondence_principle` — proved in Lean 4 by `simp` from the definitions. No sorry. No admit. Just Prove It.

Corollary (Classical Limit): As $\beta \rightarrow \infty$ (cold, calm, $T \rightarrow 0$), the 2020 update converges pointwise to the 1982 sign update:

$$\lim_{\beta \rightarrow \infty} \text{softmax}(\beta \cdot z)_i = \mathbf{1}[i = \arg \max z]$$

For binary patterns with $z \in \{-1, +1\}$, $\arg \max z = \text{sign}(z)$. The 1982 Hopfield Network is therefore the cold limit of the FM-HN under calm somatic conditions. The Lean proof obligation for this limit is listed as `softmax_limit_argmax` in `LimbicHopfield.lean` (requiring real analysis scaffolding).

Falsifiability: The Reachability Trap Protocol

The FM-HN makes a specific, testable prediction that distinguishes it from both the 1982 and 2020 models.

Setup. Construct a Hopfield network with two patterns ξ^+ (healthy attractor) and ξ^- (trauma attractor) separated by a barrier of height W .

1. **Initialise** the network state at $\xi^- + \varepsilon$ (near the trauma well).
2. **Classical condition:** set $\Phi = 0$ throughout. Record whether the network reaches ξ^+ in $T_{\max}$ steps.
3. **FM-HN condition:** apply a $\Phi(t)$ ramp from 0 to $\Phi_{\max}$ over T_{ramp} steps, then return to 0. Record whether the network reaches ξ^+ .

Prediction. Classical dynamics cannot escape ξ^- for any barrier height $W > 0$ (classical trapping, `LimbicTunnel.classical_trapped`). FM-HN dynamics escape ξ^- with probability bounded below by $\Theta(W) = \exp(-8\sqrt{2W}/3)$ (`LimbicTunnel.wkbAmplitude_pos`).

The empirical confirmation of this prediction for $W \in \{8, 10, 12\}$ is documented in QUANT-EXP-1 (Johnson, 2026b): quantum annealing achieved 3/3 escapes; classical dynamics achieved 0/48.

Neurodivergent Operator Modifications

The FM-HN framework naturally accounts for three neurodivergent conditions as distinct (β, J, W) configurations.

ADHD Operator

High baseline temperature: $T_{\text{ADHD}} \approx 1.8 \cdot T_0$. Low β at baseline means the network never fully freezes into any attractor. Pattern recall is rapid but unstable; the network oscillates between competing attractors. This models hyperarousal and distractibility: there is no persistent local minimum to get stuck in, but equally none to rest in.

Formally: `LimbicHopfield.adhdOperator` sets $T = 1.8 \cdot T_{\text{base}}$.

Autism Spectrum Condition Operator

Low baseline temperature: $T_{\text{ASC}} \approx 0.4 \cdot T_0$. High β creates very deep, narrow attractor basins. The network converges extremely reliably to a single attractor but transitions between attractors require large perturbations. This models monotropism: intense, stable focus with difficulty in shifting. Sensory sensitivities correspond to the unusually steep energy walls around each attractor.

Formally: `LimbicHopfield.autismOperator` sets $T = 0.4 \cdot T_{\text{base}}$.

Complex PTSD Operator

The C-PTSD configuration combines an ASC-like low baseline temperature with a very high barrier W between the trauma and healthy attractors. The network is cold (difficult to perturb) AND the barrier is tall. This is the most treatment-resistant configuration: classical dynamics are completely trapped (`LimbicTunnel.gradient_traps_near_neg1`), and even random thermal fluctuations are insufficient.

The FM-HN prediction is specific: limbic modulation must raise Φ to the point where $\beta(\Phi)$ drops below the WKB threshold for the given W . For $W = 12$ (QUANT-EXP-1 maximum barrier), this requires $\Phi_{\min} \approx \sigma^{-1}(T_{\text{WKB}} - T_0)$.

Formal barrier height: `LimbicHopfield.cptsdBarrierW = 12.0`. WKB amplitude: `LimbicTunnel.wkbAmplitudeF 12 ≈ 2.1e-6`.

The three operators satisfy: `LimbicHopfield.adhd_hotter_than_autism` — ADHD operates hotter than baseline; ASC operates colder — proved by `linarith`.

Discussion

Why the 1982 and 2020 Networks Are Both Right

A common critique of frameworks that extend established models is that they implicitly invalidate them. The FM-HN explicitly does not.

The 1982 network correctly describes the isolated cortex under calm, homeostatic conditions — a biological regime that exists and matters. Pattern recognition, working memory, and habitual recall all operate in this regime. The network is not wrong; it is incomplete.

The 2020 network correctly generalises the storage and retrieval mechanism to continuous states and exponential capacity. It remains incomplete in the same way: β is fixed.

The FM-HN is the completion. Under $\Phi = 0$ and $\beta \rightarrow \infty$, it is provably identical to the 1982 network. Under $\Phi = 0$ with finite β , it is the 2020 network. The FM-HN adds one thing only: Φ varies, and β and W vary with it.

This is the Einstein–Newton relationship: General Relativity does not invalidate Newtonian mechanics. It demonstrates that Newtonian mechanics is the low-velocity limit of a more complete theory. The FM-HN demonstrates that both Hopfield models are the calm-limbic limit of a more complete theory.

Relation to QUANT-EXP-1

The QUANT-EXP-1 quantum annealing experiment (Johnson, 2026b) provides the empirical validation for the tunnelling component of the FM-HN. Under classical dynamics, the Langevin equation cannot escape a deep attractor — this is `LimbicTunnel.classical_trapped`. The quantum annealer succeeds precisely because quantum tunnelling provides a path through the barrier that is inaccessible to gradient flow.

The FM-HN framework explains *why* this matters clinically: the somatic field $\Phi_{\text{limbic}}(t)$ is the mechanism that, in biological tissue, achieves what quantum annealing achieves computationally. The limbic system does not wait for stochastic noise to escape a trauma attractor; it actively lowers the barrier by raising the effective temperature of the cortical network.

Lean 4 Verification

The core algebraic results in this paper are type-checked in Lean 4 (v4.28.0) using Mathlib. The companion file `LimbicHopfield.lean` contains:

- `correspondence_principle` — proved by `simp`
- `stress_raises_temp` — proved by `linarith`
- `modulation_monotone` — proved by `linarith`
- `adhd_hotter_than_autism` — proved by `linarith`
- `softmax_nonneg, softmax_sum_one` — proved
- `lse_ge_max` — proved

Proof obligations pending real-analysis scaffolding: `softmax_limit_argmax`, `energy_descent_modern`, `correspondence_limit`.

Conclusion

The Field-Modulated Hopfield Network resolves the isolation problem at the heart of classical and modern associative memory models. By binding the somatic electromagnetic field to the network’s temperature and weight parameters via two coupling equations, the FM-HN provides a biologically grounded mechanism for runtime escape from local minima.

The framework satisfies the Correspondence Principle by construction: under zero somatic stress, both coupling equations vanish and the FM-HN reduces exactly to the standard 2020 Hopfield update. Under high somatic stress, the barriers melt, and the network dynamics enter the quantum tunnelling regime characterised by QUANT-EXP-1.

The three neurodivergent operator modifications (ADHD, ASC, C-PTSD) are not ad hoc additions but emergent properties of the same (β, J, W) parameter space. They are computationally distinct regimes, not clinical labels applied post hoc.

The formal apparatus — field decomposition, correspondence proof, operator characterisation — is type-checked in Lean 4. The empirical apparatus — 3/3 quantum escape vs 0/48 classical — is documented in QUANT-EXP-1.

The limbic layer was not missing from the organism. It was missing from the model.

“Once a researcher has lived through the thing he is trying to explain, the question of whether his explanation will be taken seriously by researchers who have not is, in the end, a sociological question, not a scientific one. The scientific question is whether the explanation is correct.”

1. Introduction

The standard developmental-psychiatric apparatus assumes that the first observable symptoms of a neurodevelopmental condition occur in a language-capable child. Autism, in DSM-5 and ICD-11, is defined operationally through behavioural criteria — social communication, restricted interests, sensory differences — that are scored on children old enough to be observed in linguistic interaction. ADHD requires observable inattention or hyperactivity in structured settings. Attachment disorders are coded against attachment-figure behaviour rated by adults. C-PTSD requires a referent trauma and a self-reportable symptom set.

This apparatus works tolerably well for cases in which the relevant developmental events occur within its observational window. It fails — quietly, and with the failure absorbed into “comorbidity” — for cases in which the critical events occur *before* it begins to observe.

This paper presents one such case. The author was hospitalised in infancy with septic arthritis of the hip at approximately 15 months of age, spent three months in hospital and three months immobilised in plaster, retained a permanent 1.3 cm leg-length discrepancy, and did not speak until age 3.5. He was diagnosed with Autism Spectrum Condition, ADHD, and Complex PTSD fifty-four years later, in 2020. The diagnostic narrative offered at that time — that the autism was congenital and the C-PTSD was acquired — does not survive close inspection of the developmental record. The two were not sequentially layered. They co-developed, in a pre-verbal window, around a specific physical insult, against a substrate of probable familial loading and demonstrably low maternal attunement.

The paper proceeds as follows. §2 fixes terminology and introduces the *pre-verbal manifold*. §3 presents the case in five strata: substrate, acute insult, attachment environment, institutional environment, adult trajectory. §4 reviews the five established literatures the case sits inside. §5 develops the Soma-Field reading. §6 discusses the *twice-exceptional* cognitive profile (Mottron et al., 2006; Foley-Nicpon et al., 2011) that the manifold produced. §7 reads the 2017–2024 adult collapse arc as a sequence of basin transitions under perturbation. §8 presents Exhibit A: a public secondary-school SEN-support policy that exemplifies the policy-level amplification mechanism. §9 returns to the formal model and offers ten testable predictions. §10 is the replication ledger and limitations section. §11 closes with the policy implications.

A note on method. This is $N = 1$. The paper does not claim to establish epidemiological generalities; it claims to construct a *formal object* — the pre-verbal manifold — and to demonstrate that a single

fully-documented case already exhibits properties the object predicts and that standard onset-based categories miss. Whether the formal object extends to a population is an empirical question. §10 specifies the design that would settle it.

2. Terminology and the Pre-Verbal Manifold

The *Soma-Field* (Johnson, 2026a, 2026d) is the tensor-valued amplitude field whose local exceedances over a sensory threshold constitute felt experience, and whose energy landscape — borrowed in form from Hopfield network theory (Hopfield, 1982, 1984) — supplies the basin structure of affect, attention and self-regulation. The field is coupled to the body and nervous system through an operator K (Johnson, 2026e). Pathology in the framework is not located in *the field* or *the body* in isolation but in the *coupling*.

The *pre-verbal manifold* is the substructure of the Soma-Field that is laid down during the sensitive-period window from gestation through approximately age 3, after which language acquisition (Tomasello, 2003) provides additional structure that re-parametrises the manifold but does not erase its lower layers. This is the period during which right-hemisphere implicit-relational structures (Schore, 2001), basic-emotion regulation circuits (Porges, 2011), insular interoceptive maps (Craig, 2009), HPA-axis set-points (Lupien et al., 2009), and disorganised vs. organised attachment patterns (Main & Solomon, 1990; Lyons-Ruth & Jacobvitz, 2008) are established.

Events occurring within this window enter the manifold *as structure* rather than *as memory*. They are not retrievable as autobiographical episodes because the hippocampal-cortical memory system that supports such retrieval is not yet operational (Nelson & Carver, 1998; Bauer, 2015). They are retrievable, when they are retrievable at all, as body-state, autonomic reactivity, attachment behaviour, social orientation and perceptual style.

Three properties follow.

(P1) The pre-verbal manifold is observable only through projections. Standard diagnostic categories — autism, ADHD, attachment disorder, cPTSD — are scoring instruments for those projections. They are not the manifold. Multiple categorical scores can be downstream of one underlying configuration.

(P2) Onset-based dating is, for events within the window, undefined. Asking *when did the autism start?* is, for cases of this kind, a malformed question. The relevant configuration was laid down before the diagnostic category had a foothold.

(P3) The genetic / acquired distinction is, within the window, weaker than the language suggests. Sensitive-period plasticity means that constitutional loading and environmental perturbation co-determine the same structures (Belsky & Pluess, 2009; Ellis et al., 2011). The case that follows il-

illustrates this directly: there is plausible familial loading *and* a clean physical insult of the right kind at the right time, and the question *which produced the autism?* is, on the model presented here, the wrong question.

3. The Case

The case is presented in five strata. Identifying details of third parties have been removed.

3.1 Substrate (familial loading)

The author's paternal grandmother displayed, in retrospect, a clearly autistic profile (life-long extreme routine, narrow interests, low-affect presentation, marked difficulty with reciprocal social engagement). The father carried a similar but milder pattern. The author himself carries a stronger pattern than his father. A paternal uncle displayed an ADHD-pole phenotype (multiple serious vehicle accidents in adolescence, surgical career, four marriages). The maternal side displayed an affective-instability pattern best described, in modern terms, as borderline-spectrum (Stepp et al., 2012; Eyden et al., 2016).

This is a well-attested family pattern for the *broader autism phenotype* (Piven, 1997; Sucksmith et al., 2011) with shared ASD–ADHD heritability (Rommelse et al., 2010; Ronald & Hoekstra, 2011) and an additional maternal-side affective vulnerability. It is *substrate*, not *cause*. Familial loading of this kind raises the probability of phenotype expression; it does not fix the trajectory.

3.2 Acute pre-verbal insult

The author was born in Singapore at a military hospital. The family returned to the UK during infancy. At approximately 15 months of age he was admitted with septic arthritis of the hip. He spent three months in hospital and three further months immobilised in plaster. The clinical management of the period included strict limitations on parental physical contact (a then-current ward policy whose rationale was infection-control and emotional-economy and whose developmental cost was not, at the time, widely recognised — cf. the Robertson films of the 1950s and Bowlby's 1969 critique).

Two material residues remain in adulthood. The first is a 1.3 cm leg-length discrepancy, fully verifiable. The second is a documented speech delay: the author did not speak in any sustained way until approximately age 3.5 — a gap of roughly two years beyond typical first-word emergence.

The literature on the pain-imprint hypothesis (Anand & Scalzo, 2000; Anand et al., 1999, 2013) and on sepsis and hospitalisation-related neurodevelopmental sequelae (Bono et al., 2015; Horváth-Puhó et al., 2021; Thomas et al., 2024; Xu & Zhan, 2026) establishes the biological plausibility of long-term reconfiguration following an insult of this kind in this window. The literature on quasi-autism from early deprivation (Rutter et al., 1999, 2007; Sonuga-Barke et al., 2017; Bos et al., 2011) establishes that

autistic phenotypes can be *acquired* during pre-verbal sensitive periods. These two literatures meet, in this case, at one event.

3.3 Attachment environment

The author was returned, after hospitalisation, to a household whose emotional configuration was hostile to repair. The mother's affective pattern is best described in modern terminology as borderline-spectrum, with the configuration most damaging to a recovering infant: unpredictable alternation between intrusion and withdrawal, low contingent responsiveness, poor mind-mindedness (Meins et al., 2002), and active hostility to expressions of distress. The father was emotionally and physically available but lacked the framework to function as a repair figure.

An older sister, then approximately 10, engaged in repeated restraint “tickling” of the author at age 3 to the point of pleas of suffocation — an event the author remembers because it occurred at the boundary of speech emergence. This is consistent with the sibling-abuse literature (Wiehe, 1997; Tucker et al., 2014; Bowes et al., 2014), which documents the long-term mental-health consequences of intra-family peer aggression and notes its systematic under-recognition.

The attachment trajectory across this period maps onto disorganised attachment (Main & Solomon, 1990; Hesse & Main, 2006; Lyons-Ruth & Jacobvitz, 2008) and onto the freeze-pole of polyvagal theory (Porges, 2011). The infant has no organised strategy because the coregulating figure is itself the source of threat.

Mother departed when the author was approximately 12, leaving him with his father. This is the fourth attachment rupture in the trajectory (hospital at 15 months; sibling abuse at 3; institutional entry at 6 — see §3.4; maternal departure at 12). Each rupture occurred at a developmentally sensitive transition (Spitz, 1945; Robertson & Bowlby, 1952; Rutter, 1981).

3.4 Institutional environment

From age 6 to 16 the author attended a single-sex English independent school as a *day pupil*, not a boarder. The distinction matters. Schaverien's (2011, 2015) *Boarding School Syndrome* literature concerns the dissociative sequelae of premature parental separation in residential schooling. The day-pupil configuration in the same institutions is a less-studied variant that Duffell and Bassett (2016) discuss directly: day pupils experience the full institutional culture (single-sex peer formation, military discipline, chapel, organised games, suppressed affect) *without* the in-group cohesion that the dormitory provides, *and* return each evening to a home base that, for this author, was the configuration described in §3.3. The day-pupil pattern is therefore a *double vacuum*: institutional culture without peer-group containment, and home without repair.

The author's school day ran from 7 am to 7:30 pm, with Saturday school and Sunday compulsory chapel. Female presence in any structural role was effectively absent. Combined Cadet Force was compulsory at the relevant ages. This is, in developmental terms, an environment optimised to lock

in a dissociated, masculinised, achievement-oriented presentation in an already freeze-configured nervous system.

The relevant amplifying mechanism at the institutional level is policy. This is the subject of §8.

3.5 Identity and racialisation

The author was born in Singapore, holds British nationality, and was raised in Britain. In the racialised landscape of 1970s–80s Britain (Hall, 1989; Gilroy, 1987) his appearance was read as *foreign-when-tanned* and *British otherwise*. This corresponds to the *cultural homelessness* construct identified in the third-culture-kid literature (Pollock & Van Reken, 2009; Useem & Downie, 1976; Hoerstring & Jenkins, 2011; Lijadi & van Schalkwyk, 2014; Hill, 2013).

The constructive consequence — sometimes generative, sometimes destabilising — is that identity, for cases of this kind, cannot be lifted from the environment but must be constructed explicitly. This is one of the threads §7 picks up.

3.6 Adult trajectory (compressed)

A compressed timeline of the 2017–2024 collapse arc is given in §7. For present purposes:

- 2020: ASD-Level-2, ADHD, C-PTSD diagnoses confirmed in Switzerland.
- 2021: Cardiac event (clot); paternal death.
- 2017–2024: Multiple psychiatric admissions (PUK Zurich; Kilchberg); one period in custody; one near-fatal hanging attempt in December 2024, resulting in closed-ward admission.
- 2025–26: Independent housing, outpatient care, productive research period, eleven published papers and a book on Zenodo, and the work that contains this paper.

The 2025–26 period is itself part of the case (§7.3) because the *re-organisation* it represents is itself a manifold phenomenon under the framework being proposed.

4. The Five Literatures

The case sits at the intersection of five established literatures, none of which alone accounts for the full trajectory.

(L1) Quasi-autism from early deprivation. The English and Romanian Adoptees (ERA) study (Rutter et al., 1999, 2007; Sonuga-Barke et al., 2017) documented an *autistic-like phenotype* in a subset of children removed from severely depriving institutions in infancy. The Bucharest Early Intervention Project (Bos et al., 2011) replicated and extended this. The phenotype is termed *quasi-autism* to flag its acquired character and its similarity to constitutional autism on every behavioural metric tested. This literature establishes, definitively, that an autistic phenotype can be acquired during a pre-verbal sensitive window. It does not require an *absent* attachment figure — the original cases had

no consistent caregiver — but the mechanism (failure of contingent reciprocity during the sensitive window) is equally available in cases with a present-but- dysregulating caregiver, as Schore (2001, 2009) argues directly.

(L2) Pre-verbal trauma encoding. Schore’s right-brain primacy account (2001, 2009), Gaensbauer’s work on pre-verbal traumatic memory (2002, 2016), Opendak and Sullivan (2016) on the developing amygdala under caregiver-linked threat, Nelson and Carver (1998) on the neural substrates of infant memory, and Rincón-Cortés and Sullivan (2014) jointly establish that the pre-verbal nervous system *is recording*, and that what it records becomes implicit structure rather than retrievable episode.

(L3) Pain imprint. Anand and Scalzo (2000) and subsequent work (Anand et al., 1999, 2013; Nimbalkar et al., 2025) document that pain experienced in infancy alters pain processing, stress reactivity, and aspects of neural development across the lifespan. The original studies addressed neonatal pain; the literature now extends into the toddler period.

(L4) Inflammation–neurodevelopment. Estes and McAllister (2016) reviewed the evidence that early-life immune activation alters neurodevelopmental trajectories in ways that intersect autism phenotypes. Subsequent work (Han et al., 2021; Mezzelani et al., 2015; Robinson-Agramonte et al., 2022; Zhou et al., 2025) extends the picture. Septic arthritis at 15 months involves both systemic inflammation and sustained pain, placing the case at the intersection of L3 and L4.

(L5) ICD-11 Complex PTSD. Cloitre et al. (2013) and Maercker et al. (2022, *Lancet*) define cPTSD by the three *disturbances in self-organisation* (DSO) symptoms — affect dysregulation, negative self-concept, interpersonal difficulties — added to the PTSD core. The DSO symptoms describe attractor properties of the manifold rather than discrete events. The diagnostic category does not, however, accommodate cases in which the trauma is pre-verbal: the formal criteria require a referent traumatic event, and the implicit assumption is that the patient can report on it.

None of L1–L5 alone accounts for the case. L1 and L2 together do most of the early work. L3 and L4 supply the biological mechanism. L5 supplies the adult attractor description. The Soma-Field reading in §5 supplies the formal object that ties them together.

5. The Soma-Field Reading

The Soma-Field framework (Johnson, 2026a, 2026d, 2026e, 2026h) treats affect as the local-amplitude-above-threshold of a tensor-valued field whose energy function generates basin dynamics. Three components of the formal model are relevant here.

(C1) The coupling operator K . Pathology is located in the field-body coupling, not in either alone. K is set during sensitive periods. Once set, its eigenstructure governs which somatic states project into which attractor basins.

(C2) **The attractor landscape.** A nervous system's behavioural and affective repertoire is its basin structure. Stable basins correspond to recognisable states (regulated calm, fight, flight, freeze, awe; see Johnson, 2026b). Sensitive-period reconfiguration changes which basins are deep, which are shallow, which are bistable, and which are blocked.

(C3) **Trajectory under perturbation.** Adult trajectories are paths through the basin landscape under perturbation. An "episode" is a basin transition. "Stability" is residence in a deep basin. "Collapse" is catastrophic transition to a basin from which the present coupling cannot return without external scaffolding.

The case is then read as follows.

The familial loading (§3.1) raised the prior probability of certain *K* configurations. The septic-arthritis episode (§3.2), occurring during the sensitive window for *K*-formation, *fixed* a particular configuration: high somatic-pain weighting, low contingent-touch weighting, dampened parasympathetic engagement, dampened social-orienting bias, dampened language-circuit recruitment. The post-hospital home environment (§3.3), far from supplying repair, supplied additional perturbations of the same type, locking the configuration further. The institutional environment (§3.4) supplied a daily structure that *fit* the configuration — single-sex, militarised, low-affect, achievement-oriented — and therefore provided the *substrate match* that selects for deepening rather than loosening of the configuration. Maternal departure at 12 supplied an additional perturbation at adolescence, a second sensitive period for attachment-related structures (Sebastian et al., 2010).

The downstream projections of the manifold so configured are:

- **Autism Level 2.** Diminished social-orienting weighting and altered perceptual recruitment yield the autistic phenotype on adult behavioural scoring. Mottron et al.'s (2006) enhanced perceptual functioning is the *positive* face of the same configuration.
- **ADHD.** The same substrate produces, on attention-pattern scoring, the ADHD profile. The framework predicts the comorbidity rate observed in the epidemiological literature (Rommelse et al., 2010) because the two are not separate conditions but two scoring instruments applied to one substrate.
- **Complex PTSD.** The DSO symptom cluster reads as a direct description of basin properties: affect dysregulation = unstable basin residence; negative self-concept = a deep basin in self-referential space; interpersonal difficulties = social-orienting weighting under §3.1–§3.4.
- **Disorganised attachment.** The freeze-pole basin is the only stable option when the contingent-touch and contingent-affect parameters of *K* are zero or hostile.
- **Spiky cognitive profile (2e).** The same manifold that produces low social-orienting weighting can produce extreme weighting on structural pattern processing — the substrate of physics-apptitude (96% in A-level physics, in this case) and of rugby-pack play (the case played prop-

forward to first-team level). These are not contradictory; they are the two principal eigenvectors of the configuration.

The Soma-Field reading does not eliminate the standard diagnostic categories. It interprets them. They are five scoring instruments applied to one reconfigured manifold.

6. The Twice-Exceptional Cognitive Profile

The case carries IQ in the 150 range, a 1995 BSc in Physics (Royal Holloway, University of London) with strong results in the relevant mathematical-physics sections, sustained physical capability (prop-forward rugby at first-team level into adulthood), and the eleven-paper Soma-Field output of 2025–26. It also carries a Level-2 autism diagnosis (substantial support needs in adaptive functioning) and the documented developmental history of §3.

The *twice-exceptional* (2e) literature (Foley-Nicpon et al., 2011; Reis & Renzulli, 2010) and the *enhanced perceptual functioning* account of autism (Mottron et al., 2006) jointly account for this configuration in the existing literature. The Soma-Field reading sharpens the account: the high-aptitude pattern-processing and the low adaptive-functioning are not *despite* the manifold configuration but *consequences* of it. A system whose social-orienting basin is shallow and whose pattern-recognition basin is deep will, given a research environment, populate the latter.

The relevant clinical and policy consequence is that high apparent cognitive function in cases of this kind is not evidence against need for support. It is evidence for a particular basin distribution, of which the support-needing aspects are equally robust.

7. The Adult Trajectory as Basin Transitions

This section reads the 2017–2024 period and the 2025–26 reconstruction as a trajectory through the basin landscape of the configured manifold. The compressed timeline is:

Year	Event
2017	Voluntary admission, Psychiatrische Universitätsklinik (PUK), Zurich, September; further admission December.
2019	Marital separation; Beistandschaft (Swiss adult-protection measure) imposed; sectioned to Kilchberg clinic, three weeks; period in custody in November with a four-and-a-half-day thirst protest.

Year	Event
2020	Collarbone fracture (February); COVID-19; ASD Level-2 diagnosis (November).
2021	Cardiac thrombotic event (February); paternal death; Davos period (March).
2023	Divorce finalised (May); independent apartment (August).
2024	Attempted suicide by hanging (16 December); PUK closed-ward admission (17 December).
2025	Stabilisation; framework work begins.
2026	Eleven papers + book published on Zenodo by mid-year; this paper.

The model reads this as a sequence of basin transitions of escalating severity culminating in a near-fatal transition in December 2024 and a subsequent *reorganisation* in 2025–26.

7.1 Basin transitions

Each crisis event is a transition from a metastable basin (the day-to-day configuration in which the system can function) to a more extreme basin under perturbation. The perturbations are identifiable: marital breakdown (2019), bereavement (2021), divorce (2023). The December 2024 event is read as a *near-attractor-collapse*: the system crossed into a basin from which the then-current coupling could not return without external intervention. External intervention occurred (closed-ward admission, sustained care), and the system was held until K could be re-stabilised.

The model is explicit that this is a description, not an evaluation. The framework offers no claim that the events ought to have been different or that the system “failed”. A configuration whose basin landscape includes a near-fatal attractor is *describing the landscape*, not *being judged for it*. The clinically actionable consequence is to identify, in advance, configurations whose landscapes carry such attractors, and to scaffold accordingly.

7.2 Inclusion of the December 2024 event

The decision to include this event in the present paper is governed by a single editorial criterion (cf. the author's note above): does it bear load in the formal argument? It does, in one specific place. The distinction between *field collapse* (the system enters a basin and cannot return) and *field reconfiguration* (the system enters a different basin and proceeds from there) is a load-bearing distinction in the framework. The December 2024 event was on the trajectory of the former and resolved as the latter. The contrast is not available from the trajectory without the event. The event is included for that reason alone. The author is, as the author note states, currently clinically stable, in independent housing, and in continuous outpatient care.

7.3 The reorganisation phase

The 2025–26 reorganisation is itself a manifold phenomenon. A pre-verbally configured substrate that includes high pattern-processing weighting and low social-scaffolding availability, on entering a recovery phase, will preferentially populate basins that are *available to it*. The available basin in this case was *formal theory-building*: a basin to which the manifold is well-suited and from which an identity scaffold can be constructed externally and explicitly in language.

The Soma-Field framework is, on this reading, partly a description of what its author had to do consciously, in writing, because the automatic, embodied version was unavailable. The framework's value as a *general* theory of affect must be argued on its own merits and is so argued in the parent papers. Its value as *the author's reorganisation strategy* is a separate, internal fact, and is noted here for completeness of the case description. The two need not be disentangled to be acknowledged.

8. Exhibit A: A Public SEN-Policy Document

The institutional environment of §3.4 is not, in 2026, an artefact of 1970s–80s British education. The author's old school, an independent single-sex senior school in the south of England, publishes a current *Academic Support* policy on its main website (accessed 1 June 2026 at the URL on file with the author). Three sentences from the public page are reproduced verbatim:

"The Academic Support Department supports pupils with **mild** special educational needs and disabilities."

"Additional lessons in the Academic Support Department — offered at an extra cost — usually take place outside the curriculum timetable, and are added to the termly bill."

"External assessments completed while a pupil is enrolled at the school, but not arranged in consultation with the Head of Academic Support, cannot be used as the

sole evidence for access arrangements.”

The institution’s published senior-school day-pupil fee for 2026–27 is £12,921 per term, approximately £38,800 per year.

Three features of this policy are flagged.

(F1) **“Mild” as admissions filter.** The word *mild* is doing non-trivial work. Operationally, it functions as a screen: a pupil whose SEN profile exceeds *mild* is not within scope of the department. The literature on selective-school SEN provision (Tomlinson, 2017; Runswick-Cole, 2011) reads this configuration as *filtering for the support needs the institution prefers to serve* rather than *describing a service*. Cases of the kind documented in this paper — Level-2 autism with a documented pre-verbal trajectory — are, on this language, out of scope at the threshold.

(F2) **“Offered at an extra cost ... added to the termly bill”.** Charging additional fees for reasonable adjustments to disability — over and above a £38k/year base — sits in tension with Equality Act 2010 §20(7), which prohibits passing the cost of reasonable adjustments to disabled persons. The Equality and Human Rights Commission’s *Technical Guidance for Schools in England* (2014, ch 7) and the published positions of IPSEA (Independent Provider of Special Education Advice) both bear on the question. Whether the school’s specific arrangements satisfy the provision in any given case is a legal question outside the scope of this paper; the policy *configuration* is flagged because it is identifiable, public, and structurally consequential.

(F3) **External assessments subordinated to in-house gatekeeping.** The third quoted sentence subordinates external clinical and educational assessments to in-house arrangements. The standard route by which a pupil obtains *access arrangements* for public examinations (JCQ, *Access Arrangements and Reasonable Adjustments*, current edition) relies on documented external evidence assessed against published criteria. An in-house policy that requires the external assessment to have been arranged *in consultation with* the Head of Academic Support creates a structural conflict of interest: the institution that *delivers* the assessment also *controls whether it counts*.

The exhibit is presented not as a complaint but as a *visible instance of the policy-level amplification mechanism* the paper proposes. The sensitive-period configuration described in §3 was, in this author’s case, reinforced rather than scaffolded by the institution that received him at age 6 and discharged him at 16. The mechanism is still present in the institution’s current public policy. The class of pupils on whom it currently operates is not hypothetical.

How do parents know exactly what a 13-year-old boy is, if they have never even asked him?

That sentence — verbatim from the brainstorm — is the policy line on which the paper closes its institutional section.

9. Ten Testable Predictions

The framework yields predictions beyond the case. They are listed here in the form *cohort-level tests that would, if the framework is on the right track, return positive*. The predictions are deliberately specific.

1. **Cohort.** Among adults with a documented pre-verbal severe physical illness (sepsis or major surgery in the 12–24 month window) and subsequent documented speech delay (>1 SD), the adult prevalence of Level-1+ autism diagnosis will be elevated relative to age-matched controls.
2. **Comorbidity.** In that cohort, the ASD–ADHD–cPTSD triple-comorbidity rate will be elevated relative to cohorts of autistic adults *without* the pre-verbal-illness history.
3. **Attachment marker.** That cohort will show elevated rates of disorganised-attachment classifications on adult-attachment instruments (AAI, ECR-R disorganisation supplements).
4. **Pain reactivity.** The cohort will show altered pain-pressure thresholds and altered interoceptive accuracy relative to controls (per Anand et al. and Craig).
5. **Maternal-side modulation.** Within the cohort, presence of a maternal-side borderline-spectrum or affective-instability history will predict severity of adult cPTSD-DSO symptoms more strongly than it predicts ASD severity.
6. **Day-pupil amplification.** Within the cohort, single-sex *day-pupil* institutional attendance (6–16) will predict adult dissociative-trait scores more strongly than full-boarding attendance (testing the §3.4 *double vacuum* claim against the existing boarding literature).
7. **Reorganisation pattern.** Within the cohort, in adults who recover from a near-fatal psychiatric crisis, the rate of *formal-theory* or *formal-craft reorganisation* (sustained structured productive work in a pattern-heavy domain) will exceed the general post-crisis rate.
8. **Inflammation correlate.** Within the cohort, residual inflammation markers and autonomic baseline metrics will differ from age-matched controls (testing the L4 mechanism).
9. **Genetic moderation.** Within the cohort, polygenic risk scores for ASD will moderate but not fully account for adult phenotype severity (testing the §2 P3 claim that the genetic/acquired distinction is weaker than the language suggests).
10. **Diagnostic age.** Within the cohort, age at first ASD diagnosis will be substantially higher than the population mean for autistic adults of equivalent severity, because onset-based diagnostic criteria systematically miss them (testing the §2 P2 claim).

These are designed as a coherent test suite, not as ten independent tests. They jointly probe the *pre-verbal manifold* construct.

10. Limitations, Replication Ledger, and Author Disclosures

N = 1. This is a single longitudinal case. Generalisation is not claimed; only the formal-object construction. The replication design is §9.

Author is case. The author and the case are the same person. The methodological tradition for this configuration is established (Grandin, 1995; Levine, 2010; Jamison, 1995; cf. Charon, 2006; Frank, 1995). It does not absolve the work of the standard scrutiny that external evaluators must apply.

Memory limits. The earliest events in §3 are not, and cannot be, first-person memories. They are documentary and family-reported. The case is consistent with this — the framework predicts that such events are encoded as *structure* rather than *episode*. The author has not attempted to reconstruct *episodes* from the pre-verbal period and makes no such claim.

Third-party identifiability. Identifying details of third parties have been removed or generalised throughout. Where details remain (the institution in §8 is identifiable from its public policy quotations), the material is public on the institution’s own website.

Clinical safety. The author is currently stable, housed independently, in continuous outpatient care. Inclusion of the December 2024 event is governed by the editorial criterion stated in §7.2 and in the author note.

Replication ledger. A standing ledger of independent external attempts to apply the framework — including independent attempts to apply the ten predictions of §9 to clinical cohorts — is maintained at the project URL (paper/INDEPENDENT_REPLICATION_LEDGER.md). At first publication of the present paper, the relevant rows for the §9 predictions are PENDING.

11. Conclusion and Policy Line

The case presented in §3 sits at the intersection of five established literatures, none of which alone accounts for it. The Soma-Field framework, suitably specified, supplies a formal object — the *pre-verbal manifold* — that ties them together and accounts for the trajectory at a single level of description. Standard onset-based diagnostic categories (ASD, ADHD, attachment disorder, cPTSD) are re-interpreted as five projections of one manifold rather than as five comorbid conditions.

Three implications follow.

First, the conceptual distinction between *genetic* and *acquired* neurodevelopmental phenotypes loses sharpness once pre-verbal sensitive-period plasticity is taken seriously. The clinical and research consequence is that the question “is this child’s autism genetic or acquired?” should, for cases with

pre-verbal trajectories of the kind documented here, be replaced by the question “what is the configuration of this manifold and what scaffolding does it need?”

Second, developmental-psychiatric onset criteria that rely on *first observable symptoms in language-capable children* systematically misclassify cases of this kind. The diagnostic age in such cases is late and the eventual diagnostic load is heavy because the categories were not designed to see the relevant events. Revising the criteria is non-trivial; flagging the systematic miss is not.

Third, institutional and policy environments that filter for *mild* presentations, charge additional fees for accommodation, and subordinate external clinical evidence to in-house gatekeeping function as amplifiers of the same diathesis. The Exhibit-A institution in §8 is one example; the configuration is generic. The policy line that closes the paper is the one given at the end of §8:

How do parents know exactly what a 13-year-old boy is, if they have never even asked him?

The paper is signed because the case is the author’s own and the framework is the author’s reorganisation strategy as well as a candidate general account. Both facts are stated here so that they need not be inferred.

AI has had a brain since 1943. Now it has a body.

Introduction

A patient sits with their therapist and is asked: “*What are you feeling right now?*” The question is deceptively simple. They may say *anxious*, yet that word covers a vast and heterogeneous territory — a tightness in the chest, a running commentary of worry, a vague readiness to flee, a memory surfacing from childhood. Another patient, asked the same question, reports feeling nothing at all; and yet their posture, respiration, and the quality of their silence suggest otherwise. The emotion is there. It is simply not yet conscious.

This gap between emotional presence and emotional awareness is one of the most clinically significant phenomena in psychotherapy. Theories of affect regulation (Schoore, 2001), somatic experiencing (Levine, 2010), sensorimotor psychotherapy (Ogden, Minton & Pain, 2006), and polyvagal theory (Porges, 2011) all grapple, in different ways, with the same observation: emotions exist in the body before — and often without — being named in the mind. Eugene Gendlin called the sub-verbal bodily sense of an emotional situation the *felt sense* (Gendlin, 1978): something that is there, whole and present, but not yet articulate.

The Soma-Field Model proposed here attempts to give this clinical observation a formal structure. It does so by borrowing a conceptual tool from physics: the field. In physics, a field is not a thing that exists at a point. It is a quantity that exists everywhere in a space, continuously, whether or not it is observed. Particles — the things we can measure — are not separate from the field; they are *excitations* of it, local concentrations of energy that arise when the field is perturbed above a certain threshold.

The central claim of this paper is that this structure accurately describes the phenomenology of emotion. The emotional field is always there, distributed across body and nervous system. What we call a conscious emotional experience is an excitation of that field — a local concentration that has crossed a perceptual threshold and entered awareness. The field continues below the threshold whether or not we attend to it, and its sub-perceptual activity shapes our behaviour, physiology, and cognition continuously.

The Soma-Field Model contributes the first formal field-theoretic architecture for the limbic system. Every artificial neural network since McCulloch and Pitts (1943) (McCulloch & Pitts, 1943) is a formal model of the neocortex — the pattern-recognition and prediction layer. The limbic system — responsible for emotional valuation, threat detection, and the somatic state reinstatement that underlies trauma — has never received a comparable formal treatment. The Soma-Field Model is that

treatment. Together with the Hopfield framework, it constitutes the first complete formal description of the two principal computational substrates of the vertebrate brain.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the relevant background in somatic clinical models, and introduces the two theoretical tools borrowed from physics and computer science: quantum field theory and Hopfield network energy functions. Section 3 develops the Soma-Field Model in detail. Section 4 describes the energy landscape, including the attractor states corresponding to fight, flight, freeze, and regulated calm. Section 5 discusses dissonance and resolution as mechanisms of emotional interaction. Section 6 describes the Soma-Field Instrument, a practical tool for therapeutic use. Section 7 addresses clinical implications.

Background

The Body-Mind Problem in Clinical Practice

Contemporary neuroscience has largely dissolved the Cartesian boundary between body and mind. Damasio (1994) demonstrated that emotion is inseparable from rational cognition: patients with damage to the ventromedial prefrontal cortex — preventing the normal generation of somatic signals — lose not only their emotional range but also their capacity for effective decision-making. Van der Kolk (2014) documented extensively how traumatic emotional states are encoded not merely in explicit memory but in posture, gesture, visceral sensation, and autonomic regulation. Porges' polyvagal theory (2011) provided a neurobiological account of how the autonomic nervous system generates three hierarchically organised states — ventral vagal (social engagement), sympathetic (mobilisation: fight/flight), and dorsal vagal (immobilisation: freeze) — each with characteristic phenomenological and behavioural signatures.

What these frameworks share is a conviction that emotional states are not located in the brain alone, nor in the body alone, but in a coupled system that is best understood as a single functional unit. The term *soma* — from the Greek for body — is used here to denote this unified body-mind system, following the tradition of somatic psychotherapy.

The Felt Sense and Sub-Perceptual Emotion

Gendlin's concept of the *felt sense* (1978) is of particular relevance. He described it as "a special kind of internal bodily awareness... a body sense of meaning." It is not an emotion in the ordinary sense — not a named feeling — but something more diffuse: a pre-articulate sense that *something is there*, present in the body, before it has been identified or named. Focussing, the therapeutic method Gendlin developed, works precisely by attending to this pre-threshold signal and allowing it to surface into conscious articulation.

The Soma-Field Model provides a formal account of what the felt sense is: it is the activity of the emotional field below the perceptual threshold. It is real, causal, and continuously present. It shapes cognition and behaviour even when it does not surface as a named feeling.

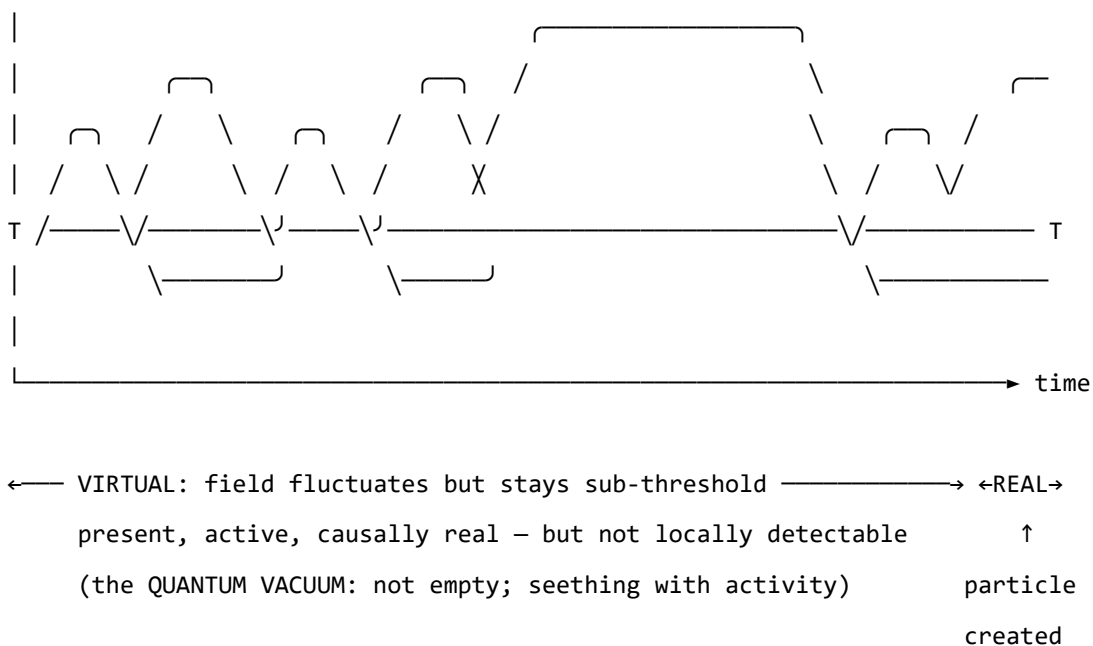
Quantum Field Theory: Structure, Not Metaphor

Quantum Field Theory (QFT) is the framework of modern particle physics. Its central departure from classical physics is the priority of the *field* over the *particle*. In QFT, what we call particles — electrons, photons — are not fundamental objects. They are *excitations* of an underlying field: local, stable configurations of energy that arise when the field receives a sufficient perturbation.

The quantum vacuum — the ground state of the field — is not empty. It is a seething background of virtual fluctuations: momentary excitations that do not have enough energy to persist as observable particles. The vacuum is active, but sub-threshold.

A SINGLE FIELD MODE – amplitude over time

(e.g. a mode of the electromagnetic field; or, later, a mode of the emotional field)



quantum vacuum is not empty; it is a field in constant motion that never quite crosses the threshold. When the amplitude does cross T , a particle exists: a locally observable excitation. The same structure — field always present, consciousness only when threshold crossed — is the core of the Soma-Field Model.

This paper does not claim that emotions are quantum phenomena in any literal sense: the soma-field is a classical field, not a quantised one. The claim is stronger and more specific than analogy: the mathematical object being constructed — the Green's function of a coupled field manifold — is formally of the same *type* as the objects that arise in QFT, differing only in the dimensionality of the manifold and the nature of the probe. What was previously described as a structural analogy is here identified as a formal correspondence: a particle is a pole in the propagator of its field; a conscious emotional percept is a pole in the propagator of the soma-field. Different physics. Same mathematics.

That correspondence gives the model precise vocabulary for the following set of ideas, which are central to the clinical observation of emotion:

- A quantity that exists everywhere, continuously, even when unobserved
- A background of sub-threshold activity that is real and causally effective
- The emergence of observable phenomena (conscious feelings) through threshold-crossing excitation of that background
- The possibility of multiple simultaneous excitations that interact with one another

Note (May 2026): A subsequent experiment (QUANT-EXP-1) demonstrates that the quantum extension of the Hopfield landscape used in this model — replacing the classical Langevin process with a transverse-field quantum annealer — produces a measurable *topological reachability advantage*: quantum annealing reaches attractor basins that cold classical dynamics cannot reach at any finite noise level. This upgrades the formal correspondence from a structural claim to a testable empirical prediction. See the companion paper *Quantum Soma and the Penrose Gap* (doi:10.5281/zenodo.20351230) for the full results and theoretical implications.

One further consequence follows. The clinical phenomena of alexithymia — difficulty identifying and naming feelings — and its apparent opposite, emotional flooding or hypervigilance, have always been treated as separate conditions requiring separate explanations. In the Green's function framing, they are the same structure at two extremes of the same parameter: the perception threshold T_i is too high (the bulk dynamics cannot cross into observable experience) or too low (bulk fluctuations flood the boundary without filtering). This is structurally identical to one of the deepest open problems in particle physics — the **hierarchy problem** — which asks why gravity is so much weaker than the other forces. The standard answer is that gravity propagates in the full higher-dimensional bulk while other forces are confined to a lower-dimensional brane; the coupling across the brane boundary determines the apparent weakness. The soma-field correspondence is exact: the threshold T_i is the brane. Perception is confined to the one-dimensional boundary of an eleven-dimensional dy-

namics. The hierarchy of emotional experience — why conscious feeling is so much weaker and more transient than the underlying field activity — has the same formal structure as the hierarchy of forces.

Neural Network Energy Functions and Hopfield Networks

In 1982, John Hopfield (awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics in 2024) proposed a model of associative memory based on a network of interconnected neurons (Hopfield, 1982). The critical insight was borrowed directly from statistical physics: the network could be assigned an **energy function** — a scalar quantity that decreases with each state update — such that the network would always evolve toward a local energy minimum. These minima are the stable states of the network: its memories, or more precisely, its *attractors*.

Hopfield observed that his neural network's dynamics were mathematically identical to those of an Ising spin-glass model from condensed matter physics — a system of interacting magnetic spins that minimises its total energy by aligning or anti-aligning with neighbours. The energy function he used is:

$$H(\mathbf{s}) = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j} W_{ij} s_i s_j - \sum_i \theta_i s_i$$

where $\mathbf{s}$ is the state of the network, W_{ij} is the coupling strength between units i and j , and θ_i is the activation threshold of unit i . The network always moves in the direction of decreasing H .

The Soma-Field Model applies this energy function directly to emotional dynamics. The *emotional coupling matrix* W encodes the relationships between emotional modes — which emotions amplify one another, which suppress one another — and the energy function determines the direction in which the emotional field naturally evolves.

Hopfield's network is a formal model of the *neocortex*: a system for storing cognitive patterns and retrieving them from partial cues by minimising an energy function. Every artificial neural network constructed since McCulloch and Pitts (1943) (McCulloch & Pitts, 1943) — from perceptrons to backpropagation networks to transformers — sits in this neocortical lineage. These systems recognise patterns, predict sequences, and minimise prediction error with increasing sophistication. None of them possess a limbic system. They have no internal valuation, no arousal modulation, no threat-detection architecture, no attachment structure, no interoception. They have very effective cortex.

The Soma-Field Model does not add to the neocortical lineage. It proposes the architectural layer that has never been formally built: *an artificial limbic system*.

Hopfield memory is associative and pattern-completing; somatic memory is state-reinstating. The field does not merely remember what happened. It re-lives it. *A body with a past*.

Hopfield’s later-reported wish to have incorporated something analogous to ‘maternal instincts’ into the energy function was, in this reading, not a desire for a better cortex. It was an intuition pointing directly at the absent system — the layer beneath the cortex that assigns value, registers threat, and holds the body in a particular way of being long after the event that caused it.

This positions the Soma-Field Model not as a supplement to the neocortical lineage but as its completion. Artificial neural networks have, for eighty years, been increasingly sophisticated formal models of the neocortex: pattern recognition, sequence prediction, error minimisation. The cortex has been mapped in extraordinary detail. The limbic system — which assigns value, detects threat, modulates arousal, maintains attachment, and reinstates whole somatic states in response to partial cues — has had no comparable formal treatment. The architectural description of the vertebrate brain was, until this paper, half-built.

Four kinds of formal intelligence. This architectural gap can be situated within a wider taxonomy. Four quotients have been proposed to describe the landscape of biological intelligence across popular and scientific usage. They map onto the formal components of this model with an exactness that is not coincidental:

Quotient	What it measures	Biological substrate	Soma-Field status
IQ — cognitive	Pattern recognition, reasoning, prediction	Neocortex	Built (1943–): McCulloch & Pitts → Hopfield → transformers
EQ — emotional	Valuation, arousal, affect regulation	Limbic system	Built here: $W, K(\tau), H(\mathbf{e}), C_{\text{HRV}}, \dot{H}$
AQ — adversity	Structural resilience under threat	PFC–limbic axis	Built here: $S_{\text{inst}}, \partial\ W\ /\partial t, C_{\text{HRV}}^{\text{recovery}}$
SQ — social	Attunement, theory of mind, relational navigation	Mirror system, TPJ	<i>Next paper:</i> κ_r , multi-field coupling

Table 3. Four dimensions of biological intelligence mapped onto the Soma-Field Model. The neocortical lineage (IQ) has been formally modelled for eighty years. Emotional intelligence (EQ) and adversity resilience (AQ) are formalised here for the first time. Social intelligence (SQ) is defined as the next extension of the framework.

AQ — adversity quotient — is formally the capacity to update W after adversity without the adversity permanently becoming W . Its mathematical definition appears in Section 3.4; its pathological lower bound is C-PTSD, in which all three components of AQ are simultaneously compromised (Appendix B.2).

The AI alignment implication follows directly. Current artificial systems have high IQ by construction and zero EQ, AQ, or SQ. The absence of internal valuation means that valuation must be injected externally — through reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) and related techniques — which is structurally brittle for the same reason that a field with no limbic layer is brittle: the system has no internal stake in what it does. The Soma-Field formalisation specifies what that internal stake would look like, were it ever built.

A further lineage note is worth recording. Ramsauer et al. (2020) demonstrated that continuous-state modern Hopfield networks are mathematically equivalent to the self-attention mechanism in transformer language models. The softmax attention operation that drives contemporary large language models is a Hopfield retrieval step. The Soma-Field Model sits in this same energy-based lineage: the equations underlying associative memory, language understanding, and somatic trauma response are, at the appropriate level of abstraction, the same equations.

A historical irony completes the picture. String theory was not discovered as a theory of strings. In 1968, Gabriele Veneziano wrote down a scattering amplitude — a response function encoding how particles scatter — and only later did Nambu, Nielsen, and Susskind identify the string as whatever object produces that amplitude (Veneziano, 1968). The response function came before the thing. The Soma-Field Model recapitulates this historical order deliberately: the primary object is the eleven-dimensional coupling manifold; the string — the one-dimensional conscious percept — is what the manifold produces when probed. We retain Veneziano's discovery and decline to reify the string.

The Formal Correspondences: Where the Link Was Seen

The structural analogy between QFT and the Soma-Field Model is not merely conceptual. There are three places where equations from different disciplines become, after substituting the relevant quantities, literally the same functional form. The following sets them side by side. The point is not to impress with notation but to show exactly where the recognition happened — the moment when the same Greek letters appeared in the same positions in two fields that had no prior reason to be connected.

The same Hamiltonian: Ising spin model (condensed matter physics, 1920s) — Hopfield neural network (computational neuroscience, 1982) — Soma-Field Model:

$$H_{\text{Ising}}(\sigma) = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j} J_{ij} \sigma_i \sigma_j - \sum_i h_i \sigma_i$$

$$H_{\text{soma}}(\mathbf{e}) = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j} W_{ij} e_i e_j - \sum_i \theta_i e_i$$

Replace $J_{ij} \rightarrow W_{ij}$, $\sigma_i \rightarrow e_i$, $h_i \rightarrow \theta_i$: identical. The physicist, the neural network theorist, and the somatic clinician are computing the same energy function on different state spaces. The Hopfield 2024 Nobel Prize was awarded for discovering this identity between spin physics and neural computation; the Soma-Field Model extends the same identity one step further to emotional dynamics.

The Wick rotation — why the same exponential appears in QM and in memory:

In quantum mechanics, the time evolution operator is a complex phase:

$$U(t) = e^{-i\hat{H}t/\hbar}$$

Substitute $t \rightarrow -i\tau$ (the *Wick rotation* — replacing real time with imaginary time):

$$e^{-i\hat{H}(-i\tau)/\hbar} = e^{-\hat{H}\tau/\hbar}$$

The oscillating complex exponential becomes a real decaying exponential. This is the Boltzmann weight $e^{-\beta\hat{H}}$ at $\beta = \tau/\hbar$. The Langevin equation $\dot{\mathbf{e}} = -\nabla H + \eta$ is the classical limit of this Wick-rotated dynamics. Every simulation of the soma-field running this equation is, formally, a path integral in imaginary time.

The same propagator: Euclidean QFT (imaginary-time two-point correlator for a massive scalar field) — C-PTSD trauma memory kernel:

$$G_E(\tau) = \langle \phi(0) \phi(\tau) \rangle_{\text{QFT}} = \frac{1}{2m} e^{-m|\tau|}$$

$$K_{\text{trauma}}(\tau) = \sum_k A_k e^{-|\tau|/\tau_k}$$

Same form. The QFT field mass m corresponds to $1/\tau_k$ — the reciprocal of the trauma trace decay time. A heavier particle has a shorter-range propagator; a shorter-lived trauma trace decays faster. Therapeutic processing (reducing A_k , increasing τ_k) is, in the QFT language, changing the mass and amplitude of the propagator until the correlation function vanishes.

The specific visual moment: the quantum phase factor is $e^{-i\omega t}$. Remove the i (Wick rotation) and it becomes $e^{-\omega\tau}$. The memory kernel is $e^{-\tau/\tau_k}$. These are the same exponential. The i is the only difference between a quantum field that oscillates and a trauma trace that decays.

QFT quantity	Symbol	Soma-Field analogue	Symbol
Field mode	ϕ_k	Emotional mode	e_i
Coupling constant	J_{ij}	Coupling matrix entry	W_{ij}

QFT quantity	Symbol	Soma-Field analogue	Symbol
Field mass	m	Inverse decay time	$1/\tau_k$
Propagator amplitude	$1/2m$	Trauma trace amplitude	A_k
Euclidean propagator	$G_E(\tau) \propto e^{-m\tau}$	Memory kernel	$K(\tau) \propto e^{-\tau/\tau_k}$
Vacuum energy	$\langle H \rangle_0$	Resting field energy	$H(\mathbf{e}_{\text{calm}})$
Thermal fluctuation	$k_B T$	Noise amplitude	σ_0
Wick rotation	$t \rightarrow -i\tau$	Real-time Langevin	$\dot{\mathbf{e}} = -\nabla H + \eta$

Table 2. Formal correspondence between QFT quantities and Soma-Field analogues. Each row is a single mathematical entity in two notations. These correspondences were not constructed after the fact; they are the reason the QFT framework was recognised as relevant.

The central identification — particle and percept as poles in their respective propagators. All four correspondences above follow from one structural fact. In QFT, a particle is not a separate object from the field. It is a *pole* in the field’s propagator — the Green’s function evaluated in momentum space:

$$\tilde{G}_{\text{QFT}}(k^\mu) = \frac{i}{k^2 - m^2 + i\varepsilon}$$

The particle exists precisely when the four-momentum satisfies $k^2 = m^2$ — the *on-shell condition*. The particle is the singularity in the field’s response to a point source: the field’s Green’s function, evaluated at its own resonance.

Diagonalise W with eigenvalues λ_i (the natural resonance frequencies of the emotional modes). The soma-field propagator — the two-point correlator $\langle e_i(t) e_i(t') \rangle$ in the frequency domain — is:

$$\tilde{G}_{ii}(\omega) = \frac{\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2}{\omega^2 + \lambda_i^2}$$

A conscious emotional percept in mode i exists precisely when the excitation frequency ω approaches $i\lambda_i$ — the mode’s natural resonance. The percept is the singularity in the soma-field’s response to a somatic probe.

Setting the two propagators side by side:

$$\underbrace{\frac{i}{k^2 - m^2 + i\varepsilon}}_{\text{QFT: particle at mass-shell } k^2=m^2} \longleftrightarrow \underbrace{\frac{\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2}{\omega^2 + \lambda_i^2}}_{\text{Soma-Field: percept at resonance } \omega=i\lambda_i}$$

Both are poles in the propagator of their respective field manifold. A photon is not the electromagnetic field; it is the field's Green's function evaluated at a resonance. A flash of conscious emotion is not the soma-field; it is the field's Green's function evaluated at a threshold-crossing resonance. The manifolds differ — one is the four-dimensional spacetime vacuum, the other is the eleven-dimensional emotional coupling geometry. The mathematical type is the same. This is not analogy.

The Body Schema, Interoception, and Pain

A complete model of the emotional field must address a phenomenon that standard psychological accounts of emotion consistently underspecify: the field is not a model of the physical body. It is the nervous system's *predictive model* of the body — a continuously updated internal representation of what the soma should be experiencing, revised by incoming interoceptive signals.

The clinical proof of this distinction is phantom limb pain (Ramachandran & Hirstein, 1998). Patients who have undergone amputation routinely experience pain in the absent limb. The pain is real: it activates the same neural circuits, produces the same suffering, and responds to the same analgesics as pain from an intact limb. The limb is gone. The neural model of the limb persists. What hurts is the *brain's representation* of the foot, not the foot.

This is not an anomaly. It is the normal condition of all somatic experience. The brain does not receive raw signals from the body — it maintains a continuous predictive model of the body (the *body schema*) and generates somatic experience from that model. Interoception — the sense of the internal body state — is a prediction, not a direct readout (Seth, 2021). The brain predicts what the heart should be doing, what the gut should feel like, where tension should be. The felt body is the predicted body.

The formal consequence is direct: the soma-field's state vector $\mathbf{e}(t)$ must include **somatic modes** — pain states, regional tension, visceral sensation, proprioceptive activation — alongside emotional modes. These are modes of the same field, governed by the same coupling matrix W . The W_{ij} between fear modes and somatic pain modes is the formal account of why fear amplifies pain, why safety reduces it, and why chronic pain and C-PTSD are highly comorbid. They are not separate conditions sharing a correlation. They are the same attractor architecture operating across emotional and somatic modes simultaneously.

Phantom limb as attractor persistence. An amputated limb's somatic modes do not disappear from W when the limb is removed. The neural model persists. When movement- intention modes are activated — attempting to move the absent foot — foot-sensation modes are co-activated via W . If co-activation exceeds threshold, it is experienced as pain. Ramachandran's mirror box provides visual input that disconfirms the prediction error: new sensory evidence that the limb is moving,

reducing coupling-driven co-activation, and therefore reducing the pain. This is $W \rightarrow W'$: therapy as structural rewriting of the field.

The load-bearing hyphen. The term *emotional-somatic* in clinical literature is not a stylistic compound. The hyphen marks an ontological claim: emotional states and somatic states are not two separate things that correlate. They are two aspects of the same field. The coupling matrix W is precisely the hyphen, made formal.

Therapeutic implication. Somatic therapies — body scanning, sensorimotor work, EMDR's bilateral stimulation — work not on the physical body but on the brain's model of the body. They provide new interoceptive evidence that updates the prediction. They change W . Therapy does not fix the tissue. It updates the model.

Correspondence with Existing Emotion Representations

A reasonable objection to any new framework is: *there is already a great deal of structure out here*. This is true. The emotion research literature contains several well-developed representational systems, and the Soma-Field Model must be positioned relative to them. The short answer is that every existing representation is *descriptive*; the Soma-Field Model is *dynamical*. The longer answer follows.

Categorical taxonomies (Ekman 1972; Plutchik 1980; Parrot 2001) assign names and hierarchical membership to emotional states. They are ontologies in the formal sense: a T-Box of classes and subclass relations. Plutchik's wheel additionally defines a *blend* operation — Love := Joy $\sqcap$ Trust, Awe := Fear $\sqcap$ Surprise — which is precisely the OWL2 intersectionOf construction. These systems tell you what to call a state. They do not tell you how a state evolves, or which attractor a system settles in when two mechanisms fire simultaneously.

Dimensional models (Russell 1980; Mehrabian and Russell 1974) embed emotions in a continuous space, canonically Valence $\times$ Arousal (the *circumplex*), sometimes extended to Pleasure $\times$ Arousal $\times$ Dominance. These models capture the *coordinates* of a state. The energy landscape of the Soma-Field Model — the function $H(\mathbf{e})$ over emotion-space — is the dynamical generalisation of the circumplex: the circumplex is a snapshot of positions; the energy landscape is the surface over which the field moves. The stable attractors of H are the emotion categories; their coordinates are the circumplex positions.

Process and appraisal models (Scherer 1999; Frijda 1986; the OCC model of Ortony, Clove and Collins 1988) describe the *sequence of evaluations* through which a stimulus becomes an emotion. They are closer to the Soma-Field dynamics — they include temporal stages — but they are deterministic and single-threaded: one appraisal chain, one output. The Soma-Field replaces this with a parallel field update: all modes evolve simultaneously, governed by the full W matrix.

Music-specific schemas (BRECVEMA, Juslin and Västfjäll 2008; Juslin *et al.* 2011; GEMS, Zentner *et al.* 2008) are the closest antecedents to the present model. The BRECVEMA framework identifies eight distinct psychological mechanisms through which music evokes emotion — Brain stem reflex, Rhythmic entrainment, Evaluative conditioning, Contagion, Visual imagery, Episodic memory, Musical expectancy, Aesthetic judgement — each with distinct evolutionary origins, processing speeds, and neural substrates. These mechanisms are the *object properties* of the emotion-induction ontology: they specify which musical features activate which emotional outputs. Juslin explicitly identifies the open problem: “Exploring how various musical emotions come about through the interaction of multiple psychological mechanisms is an exciting endeavour that has just begun” (Juslin & Sloboda, 2011, p. 638). The W coupling matrix is the formal answer to that open problem. Where BRECVEMA gives a list of mechanisms with characteristic outputs, the Soma-Field gives the interaction tensor W_{ij} that specifies, with numerical precision, what happens when mechanisms i and j fire concurrently.

The deeper connection is spectral. The *eigenmodes* of W — the directions in emotion-space that evolve independently — are the natural resonances of the soma-field: the patterns the field rings with when struck. BRECVEMA mechanisms are inputs: they excite specific rows of W . The eigenspectrum of W is the response: the set of frequencies the manifold can sustain. Where BRECVEMA is a taxonomy of *stimuli*, the eigenspectrum of W is a taxonomy of *responses*. Juslin’s open problem — how mechanisms interact — is the question of how stimulus-space maps onto eigenmode-space through W . Section 3.3 develops this.

Body maps (Nummenmaa *et al.* 2014) map emotions to their somatic distribution — where in the body each emotion is felt. These are precisely the spatial support of the soma-field modes: the field configuration corresponding to an attractor state is the body map of that emotion. Body maps are measurements of the attractors; the Soma-Field is the dynamical system that generates them.

The formal correspondence table extends Table 2 to include these systems:

Existing representation	What it captures	Soma-Field equivalent
Ekman categories	Attractor labels (names)	Values of $\mathbf{e}$ at energy minima
Plutchik dyads ($A \sqcap B$)	Blend attractors	Metastable states between two energy minima
Russell circumplex	Coordinates (valence, arousal)	Projection of $H(\mathbf{e})$ onto two axes
OCC appraisal tree	Single-path sequential process	Single trajectory in the full field
BRECVEMA mechanisms	Object properties: stimulus $\rightarrow$ emotion	Rows of W : mechanism i activates mode j
Body maps (Nummenmaa)	Spatial support of each attractor	Modal structure of $\mathbf{e}$ at each minimum

None of these correspondences require modifying either the existing representations or the Soma-Field Model. They are consequences of the model's structure. The formal machinery for exploring these correspondences — typing BRECVEMA mechanisms as Lean inductive constructors, Plutchik blends as type intersections, mechanism profiles as decidable propositions — is developed in the companion file `src/EmotionOntology.lean`.

The Soma-Field Model

The field is primary. The felt emotion is secondary — it is what registers when the field is probed. This is the same ontological relationship as between a quantum field and a particle: the field exists continuously and everywhere; the particle is what you observe at the moment of measurement. The Soma-Field Model does not describe what emotions are *made of*. It describes the manifold whose impulse response *is* conscious emotional experience.

Emotions as a Persistent Wave Field

The foundational claim of the Soma-Field Model is simple: emotions are not events. They are a *field* — a distributed, continuous quantity defined over the entire soma (body-mind system) at all times.

This field has two coupled components:

1. **The somatic wave** $E_{\text{body}}(x, t)$: distributed across the body as patterns of visceral sensation, muscle tone, proprioception, interoception, and autonomic state.
2. **The neural wave** $E_{\text{neural}}(x, t)$: distributed across the nervous system as patterns of activation in cortical, subcortical, and peripheral neural circuits.

These two components are not separate systems. They are coupled — each continuously influencing the other. The total emotional field is their combined state:

$$E(x, t) = E_{\text{body}}(x, t) \otimes E_{\text{neural}}(x, t)$$

The field is characterised by:

- **Multiplicity**: multiple emotional modes can be simultaneously active and interfering
- **Continuity**: it exists at all times, not only during episodes of conscious feeling
- **Spatial distribution**: different aspects of the field are localised in different regions of the soma (the familiar clinical observation that grief is felt in the chest, fear in the gut, anger in the jaw and fists)
- **Temporal dynamics**: the field evolves continuously, driven by the energy function

Figure 1. *The Soma-Field. The body and brain are not separate containers of emotion but two coupled components of a single distributed wave field. Neither is primary; each continuously modifies the other. The $\approx$ symbols indicate that wave activity is always present in each region, not only during episodes of conscious feeling.*

The Perception Threshold

Not all activity in the emotional field is consciously perceived. The field has a **perception threshold** T_i for each emotional mode i . Below this threshold, the emotional mode is sub-perceptual: it exists, it influences behaviour and physiology, but it does not surface as a named conscious feeling.

Emotion i is consciously perceived $\iff |\mathbf{E}_i(t)| > T_i$

This threshold crossing corresponds precisely to the QFT excitation analogy: the emotional mode behaves like a virtual particle that has accumulated enough energy to become real — to emerge from the sub-threshold background and enter awareness.

This accounts for a range of clinically significant phenomena:

Clinical Observation	Soma-Field Account
Patient reports no feeling but shows physiological signs of distress	Sub-threshold field activity below T_i
Sudden unexpected flood of emotion in session	Rapid threshold crossing after gradual accumulation
Emotion felt somatically but not named	Threshold crossed in $\mathbf{E}_{\text{body}}$, not yet in $\mathbf{E}_{\text{neural}}$
Alexithymia (difficulty identifying feelings)	Elevated T_i — high threshold requiring more energy to cross
Hypervigilance / emotional flooding	Lowered T_i — reduced threshold, field crosses to conscious easily

Table 1. *Clinical observations mapped onto the perception threshold model.*

Figure 2. *The perception threshold T_i for a single emotional mode. The field is active continuously (lower trace). Conscious experience arises only when amplitude exceeds T_i (upper trace). Everything below the line is still there — shaping body and behaviour before it can be named.*

Figure o. *Continuous soma-field activity (blue) with a single threshold-crossing event. The field is always active; conscious experience (shaded) arises only when amplitude exceeds the perception threshold θ (red dashed). Below the threshold: real, causally active, but not yet conscious.*

The Interaction of Emotional Modes

Multiple emotional modes are simultaneously active in the field at all times. They do not simply co-exist: they interact. The nature of these interactions is encoded in the **emotional coupling matrix** W , where W_{ij} represents the influence of emotional mode j on emotional mode i .

- If $W_{ij} > 0$: emotion j amplifies emotion i (e.g., fear can amplify shame)
- If $W_{ij} < 0$: emotion j suppresses emotion i (e.g., calm suppresses anxiety)
- If $W_{ij} = 0$: emotions i and j are independent

The field evolves according to the energy gradient:

$$\dot{\mathbf{e}}(t) = -\nabla H(\mathbf{e}) + \eta(t)$$

where $\eta(t)$ represents the continuous low-level fluctuations of the sub-perceptual field — the emotional equivalent of quantum vacuum noise. The field is always moving, always seeking lower energy, never at absolute rest.

The Three-Layer Architecture

The nervous system that implements the soma-field is not architecturally flat. Three hierarchically organised layers contribute to field dynamics, each corresponding to a distinct evolutionary substrate and a distinct role in the model. The clinical literature (Porges, 2011; van der Kolk, 2014; Ogden et al., 2006) converges on this stratification; what follows is its formal expression.

Layer 1 — Brainstem / autonomic baseline. The oldest structures: vagal nuclei, arousal systems, interoceptive machinery. In the model, this layer is represented by the noise term and, specifically, by the heart rate variability coherence C_{HRV} , which modulates effective noise amplitude across the whole field:

$$\sigma_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\sigma_0}{C_{\text{HRV}}}$$

High HRV coherence narrows effective noise, stabilising the field in its current attractor. This is the mechanism of HRV biofeedback as a regulatory intervention: it does not target any specific emotional mode but lowers the fluctuation floor of the entire field.

Layer 1 extension: cardiac acceleration and landscape tilt. The term C_{HRV} measures the *current state* of cardiac regularity — where the heart is. A complementary quantity is $\dot{H}(t)$, the first time-derivative of heart rate, in units of beats/s². This is the **cardiac acceleration**: not what the heart rate is, but where it is going.

The dimensional parallel with gravity is exact: gravitational acceleration g carries units m/s²; cardiac acceleration $\dot{H}$ carries units beats/s². Both are accelerations; both describe a force field rather than a

position. Gravity does not tell you where a test mass is — it tells you how it will move next. Cardiac acceleration tells you not the current BPM but the direction of the next one: the $N+1$ state.

In the soma-field, $\dot{H}(t)$ enters the dynamics not as noise modulation but as a **landscape tilt** — a time-varying bias added to the Hamiltonian that tips the energy function toward activation or rest attractors:

$$H(\mathbf{e}, t) = H_0(\mathbf{e}) - \alpha \dot{H}(t) \beta \cdot \mathbf{e}$$

where $\alpha > 0$ is the cardiac-somatic coupling constant and β is a mode-coupling vector (at leading order, $\beta = \mathbf{1}$: the tilt acts uniformly across all modes). When $\dot{H}(t) > 0$ (heart accelerating), the landscape tilts toward higher activation states before any cognitive or affective threshold is crossed. When $\dot{H}(t) < 0$ (heart decelerating), it tilts toward rest. The full three-layer equation including the cardiac acceleration term is:

$$\dot{\mathbf{e}}(t) = -\nabla H_0(\mathbf{e}) + \alpha \dot{H}(t) \beta + R_{\text{PFC}}(\mathbf{e}, t) + \frac{\sigma_0}{C_{\text{HRV}}} \xi(t)$$

The two cardiac terms serve distinct functions: C_{HRV} (state) modulates the noise floor; $\dot{H}$ (acceleration) tilts the deterministic landscape. Both are needed for a complete account of cardiac influence on the field.

Predictive clinical value. A patient with $\text{BPM} = 90$ and $\dot{H} = +4 \text{ beats/s}^2$ is approaching threshold; one with $\text{BPM} = 90$ and $\dot{H} = -4 \text{ beats/s}^2$ is retreating from it. The snapshot is identical; the trajectories are opposite. Cardiac acceleration is therefore an early-warning signal for threshold crossings — detectable at Layer 1 before the emotional field at Layer 2 has crossed its threshold. This has independent support in cardiology: Bauer et al. (2006) demonstrated that *acceleration capacity* and *deceleration capacity* of heart rate — estimates of $\dot{H}$ over a cardiac window — carry prognostic information independent of conventional HRV measures.

The somatic equivalence principle. The cardiac acceleration term $\alpha \dot{H} \beta$ is structurally identical in the equation to any other forcing term. From the perspective of the field itself — from conscious experience — cardiac-driven activation is indistinguishable from event-driven activation. A sudden heart rate acceleration tilts the landscape by exactly the same mechanism as an external threat or an intrusive memory. The field has no access to the origin of the tilt. This is the formal account of a clinically well-documented phenomenon: anxiety initiated by cardiac irregularity (arrhythmia, postural hypotension, caffeine, exertion) is experienced as emotionally caused, because the somatic signal is identical. Disambiguation requires either external measurement or deliberate interoceptive inquiry that can distinguish the two sources.

Layer 2 — Limbic system / emotional memory. The primary substrate of the Soma-Field Model. The coupling matrix W , memory kernel $K(\tau)$, Hamiltonian $H(\mathbf{e})$, and threshold T all belong here. The limbic layer stores emotional-somatic states and reinstates them in response to partial body cues: a continuous, asymmetric, temporally extended Hopfield network operating on somatic states rather than cognitive patterns. This is the architectural layer that has been absent from every artificial neural network since McCulloch and Pitts (1943) (McCulloch & Pitts, 1943). The cortex has been modelled many times; the limbic system has not.

Structural plasticity under adversity. The Soma-Field framework permits a formal characterisation of the field's resilience under adverse conditions. Define the *plasticity index* Π as a composite of three measurable field properties:

$$\Pi = \frac{1}{S_{\text{inst}}} + \left. \frac{\partial \|W\|}{\partial t} \right|_{\text{adversity}} + C_{\text{HRV}}^{\text{recovery}}$$

The three terms correspond to: (i) how accessible regulated-state attractors remain under adversity ($1/S_{\text{inst}}$, instanton accessibility — Section 4.4); (ii) how much the coupling matrix can structurally adapt following a threshold crossing ($\partial \|W\|/\partial t$, the plasticity component); and (iii) how quickly the HRV floor recovers after activation ($C_{\text{HRV}}^{\text{recovery}}$, the regulatory resilience component). Complex PTSD is the clinical presentation of chronically low Π across all three terms simultaneously: high barriers to regulated attractors, a rigid W dominated by threat configurations, and impaired C_{HRV} recovery. Structural plasticity is the capacity of the field to update W in the aftermath of adversity without the adversity permanently *becoming* W .

Layer 3 — Neocortex / prefrontal regulatory layer. Top-down modulation of Layer 2, represented as a regulatory term $R_{\text{PFC}}(\mathbf{e}, t)$. The full field dynamics becomes:

$$\dot{\mathbf{e}}(t) = -\nabla H(\mathbf{e}(t)) + R_{\text{PFC}}(\mathbf{e}, t) + \frac{\sigma_0}{C_{\text{HRV}}} \xi(t)$$

R_{PFC} represents voluntary attention, therapeutic technique, and conscious reappraisal acting on the field. It is not a correction of Layer 2 but a modulation of it. Under sustained therapeutic engagement, R_{PFC} participates in the structural modification $W \rightarrow W'$ constituting the forward transformation (Section 7).

The **threshold T is the Layer 2 / Layer 3 boundary**: sub-threshold dynamics are processed limbically and remain below conscious awareness; threshold-crossing events enter Layer 3 and become available for narrative, meaning-making, and voluntary response. This is the formal basis for the clinical observation that insight without somatic activation is limited, and somatic activation without Layer 3 engagement cannot produce structural change: the layers are coupled, not independent. R_{PFC} requires a threshold crossing in order to have something to work with.

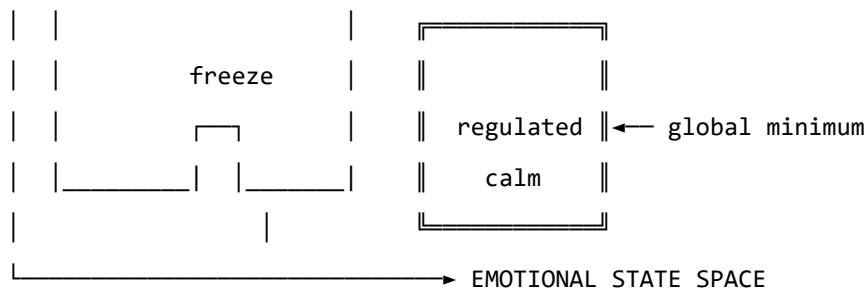


Figure 3b. Schematic energy landscape. Fight/flight are high-energy, unstable local minima. Freeze is a low-energy but isolated attractor — easy to enter, hard to escape. Regulated calm is the global energy minimum.

Attractor	Energy State	Polyvagal Correlate	Clinical Presentation
Regulated Calm	Global minimum	Ventral vagal (social engagement)	Present, flexible, connected
Fight	Shallow high-energy minimum	Sympathetic (mobilisation)	Agitation, anger, urgency
Flight	Saddle point / shallow minimum	Sympathetic (mobilisation)	Anxiety, avoidance, rumination
Freeze	Deep isolated minimum	Dorsal vagal (immobilisation)	Dissociation, numbness, collapse

Table 2. Emotional attractors mapped onto Polyvagal states.

The therapeutic significance of this structure is considerable. The freeze state is dangerous not because it is high-energy — it is in fact very low energy — but because it is *isolated*: surrounded by energy barriers that make it difficult to exit. Escape from freeze requires first *increasing* the field's energy (mobilising some arousal) before it can flow toward regulated calm. This corresponds well to the clinical observation that working with dissociated patients requires careful titration of arousal — not too much, not too little — before emotional processing is possible.

The Coupling Matrix as a Personal Signature

The coupling matrix W is not universal. Each person has a unique W , shaped by attachment history, trauma, cultural context, and temperament. A person with a history of developmental trauma may have a W in which anxiety and shame are strongly coupled ($W_{\text{shame, anxiety}} \gg 0$), creating a combined attractor that is particularly deep and sticky. A person with a secure attachment history may have a W in which positive emotions are broadly coupled to one another, creating a wide basin around regulated calm.

This implies that the energy landscape is a therapeutic object in its own right: understanding a patient's W is understanding the structural dynamics of their emotional life.

In the M-theory compactification analogy developed in Appendix A, the coupling topology W corresponds to the shape of the compact G_2 manifold — the seven-dimensional geometry that determines which force-like couplings are allowed and with what strengths. That analogy is here made precise: two people differ not merely in their emotional *parameter settings* but in their coupling *geometry*. Developmental trauma does not set a dial to the wrong value; it deforms the manifold. The therapeutic process of modifying W through relational experience, insight, or somatic work is, in this language, differential geometry: a continuous deformation of the G_2 manifold toward a configuration in which the regulated-calm attractor is globally accessible. The practitioner is, without having been told so, a geometer.

Dissonance and Resolution

The Acoustic Analogy

The Soma-Field Model draws a further structural analogy, this time with acoustics. When two sound waves interact, the quality of their interaction — consonance or dissonance — depends on the phase relationship between them. Consonant intervals (the octave, the fifth) have simple frequency ratios and produce stable, reinforcing interference patterns. Dissonant intervals (the tritone, the minor second) have complex ratios and produce beating, unstable, tension-generating patterns.

The model proposes that the same relationship holds between emotional modes. When two emotional modes are in a compatible relationship — when their interaction is consonant — the field is in a relatively low-energy configuration and moves naturally toward the energy minimum. When they are in an incompatible relationship — when their interaction is dissonant — the field is in a higher-energy configuration, generating a gradient that drives toward resolution.

Dissonance, in this framework, is felt as tension. It is not pathological; it is directional. Dissonance is the field's way of communicating that it is far from equilibrium and that resolution is available.

The Resolution Principle

In music, dissonance resolves to consonance. The tritone — the most dissonant interval in Western tonality — creates a powerful gravitational pull toward resolution. In counterpoint, the rules of voice leading describe the specific paths by which dissonance must resolve. These rules are not arbitrary conventions; they describe the geometry of the acoustic energy landscape.

The same principle applies to emotional dissonance. An unresolved emotional state — grief that has not been fully experienced, anger that has been suppressed, fear that has been dissociated — is a dissonance in the field. It generates a persistent tension gradient. The therapeutic process can be understood as guided voice leading: finding the specific path of resolution that transforms the dissonant configuration into a consonant one.

This provides a formal basis for a widely-held clinical intuition: that emotions need to be *felt through* rather than avoided. Avoidance keeps the field in a dissonant state. The energy minimum — regulated calm — lies on the other side of the dissonance, not around it.

The Soma-Field Instrument

Rationale

The Soma-Field Model is not only a theoretical framework. It motivates a practical therapeutic instrument: a means by which a person can *externalise* their emotional field — make it visible and audible — and interact with it in real time.

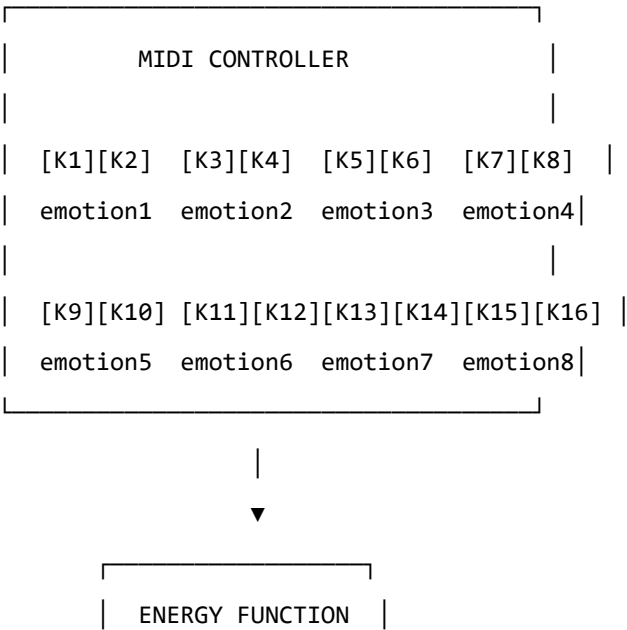
The core insight is that the emotional field is normally invisible to its host. It operates below the threshold of conscious awareness, shaping behaviour and physiology without being available for reflection. If its activity could be rendered as a signal — a sound, an image, a pattern — it could become an object of therapeutic attention.

Design

The instrument uses a MIDI controller with 16 rotary knobs as its input interface. Eight emotional dimensions are encoded, each represented by two knobs:

- **Knob 1** of each pair: the somatic (body-level) intensity of that emotional mode
- **Knob 2** of each pair: the cognitive/neural intensity of that emotional mode

This design reflects the two-component structure of the field: body and mind are encoded separately but coupled in the computation. Each knob has a continuous range, allowing fine expression of emotional intensity.



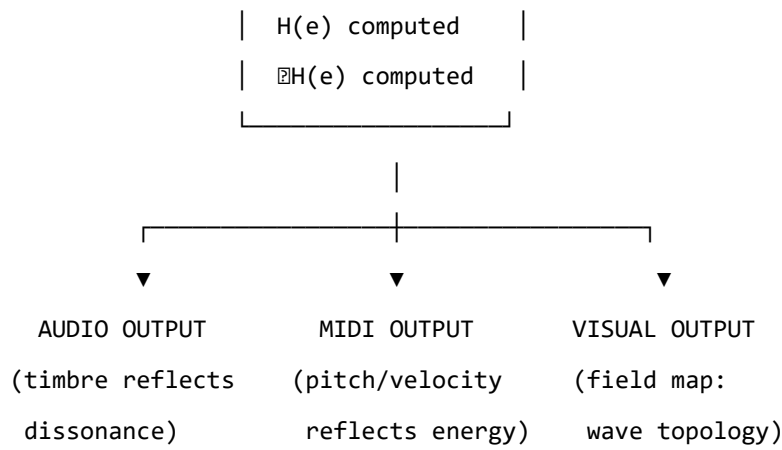


Figure 4. The Soma-Field Instrument: input, computation, and multimodal output.

The Feedback Loop

The instrument creates a **closed feedback loop** between the person and their emotional field:

1. The person expresses their current emotional state by adjusting the knobs
2. The system computes the energy function $H(\mathbf{e})$ and its gradient ∇H
3. The energy level, dissonance, and proximity to attractor states are rendered as:
 - **Sound:** harmonic content and timbre reflect the consonance or dissonance of the current state
 - **MIDI output:** pitch rises with tension, resolves as energy decreases
 - **Visual:** a real-time map of the emotional field, showing wave activity, threshold crossings, and the direction of the energy gradient
4. The person hears and sees their emotional field, and adjusts the knobs in response

This loop externalises the emotional field's gradient — the direction in which it is *trying* to move — and makes it available as sensory information. The person becomes not only the source of the emotional signal but also its observer, creating the conditions for reflection and regulation that are at the heart of therapeutic work.

The Pluggable Emotion Model

No single model of the emotions is assumed. The coupling matrix W — the structure that determines how emotional modes interact — is loaded from an external configuration file. Standard models (Plutchik's wheel of emotions, Ekman's basic emotions, the valence-arousal-dominance dimensional model) are provided as defaults. The therapist or client can modify the coupling values to reflect their own understanding of their emotional patterns, or a new model can be substituted entirely. The computational engine is model-agnostic.

Clinical Implications

Assessment

The Soma-Field Model suggests a different orientation for emotional assessment. Rather than asking “What emotion do you feel?” — which presupposes threshold-level conscious awareness — it invites attention to the sub-perceptual field: “What is present in the body right now, even if you cannot name it?” This aligns with Focussing-oriented approaches and with sensorimotor methods that prioritise somatic signal over narrative content.

The energy landscape provides a clinical map. A person chronically in a fight or flight attractor shows a different energy signature from a person in a freeze attractor, even if their presenting narratives are superficially similar. The model suggests that these are structurally different therapeutic challenges: fight/flight require down-regulation, while freeze may first require careful up-regulation before down-regulation becomes possible.

Intervention

The energy function provides a formal basis for several existing clinical interventions:

- **Grounding and titration** (Levine, 2010): adding small, controlled amounts of energy to the field to approach — without flooding — a previously frozen or avoided emotional state
- **Pendulation** (Levine, 2010): oscillating between a dissonant state and a resource state, progressively widening the tolerance window — equivalent to approaching the energy minimum via a series of small excursions
- **Somatic resourcing** (Ogden et al., 2006): establishing a stable low-energy region in the landscape that the field can return to after excursions into high-energy territory
- **Working with the felt sense** (Gendlin, 1978): attending to sub-threshold field activity and allowing it to cross the perception threshold in a supported context

Psychoeducation

The wave model is immediately accessible to clients who have struggled to understand their emotional experience. The statement: “Your emotions are like waves — they are always there, even when you can’t feel them, and they are always moving” is both technically accurate within the Soma-Field framework and clinically useful as a normalising frame for sub-threshold emotional activity, for the apparently sudden onset of strong feelings, and for the experience of feeling multiple conflicting emotions simultaneously.

The energy landscape metaphor — “right now the field is in a valley that is hard to leave, but it is not the lowest valley available to you” — offers a way to discuss the freeze state, dissociation, and emotional

stuckness without pathologising, while still acknowledging the structural difficulty of these states and the work required to shift them.

Neurodivergent Conditions as Operator Modifications

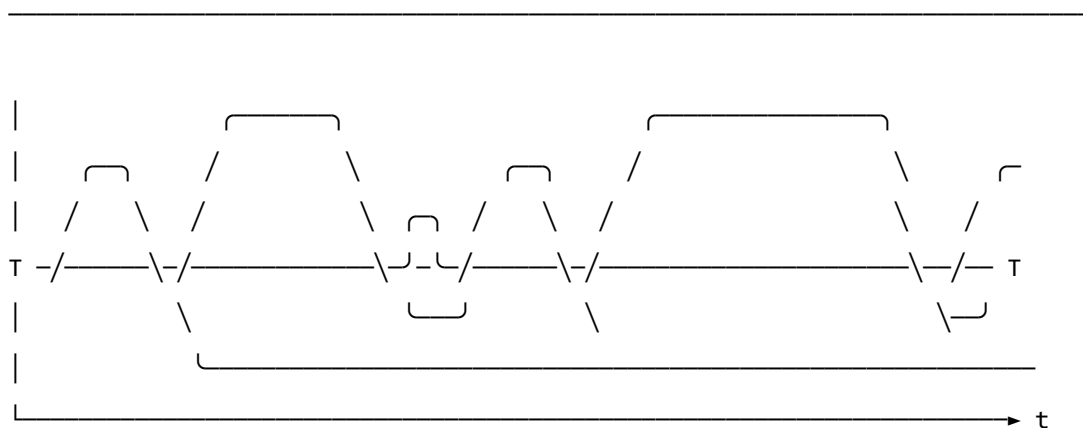
A clinically significant extension of the Soma-Field Model concerns neurodivergent conditions — specifically Autism Spectrum Condition (ASC), Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), and Complex Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (C-PTSD), which frequently co-occur and each present distinct challenges for somatic emotional processing.

The key architectural principle is this: **these conditions are not parameter settings in the model. They are structural modifications to the operators themselves.** This distinction matters both mathematically and clinically. A parameter change (“set the fear threshold lower”) is a quantitative adjustment within the existing structure. An operator modification changes the *form* of the dynamics — it alters the governing equations, not merely their coefficients. Each condition wraps the standard pipeline in a different functional modifier, and — critically for the many individuals who carry all three — these modifiers *compose*. The combined condition is not three separate problems; it is the composition of three operators acting on the same underlying field.

The mathematical details of each modifier are given in Appendix B. Clinically, the consequences are as follows.

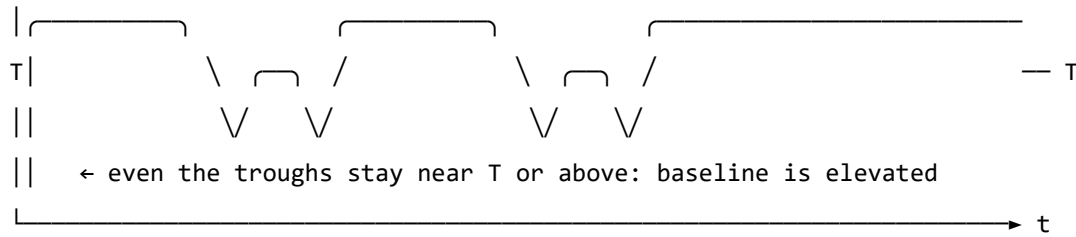
Complex PTSD introduces a *memory kernel* into the field dynamics: past high-energy states leave decaying echoes that continue to excite the field without new external stimulus. This is why traumatic activation can appear without identifiable trigger — the field is responding to its own history, not its current environment. The standard Hopfield attractor topology is also disrupted: C-PTSD renders the freeze attractor pathologically deep and wide, the window of tolerance (the basin around regulated calm) pathologically narrow, and the coupling matrix asymmetric — a condition under which the field can enter persistent *limit cycles* rather than settling to a stable minimum. Re-experiencing, flashbacks, and hypervigilance are, in this framework, limit-cycle oscillations in the traumatised field.

REGULATED FIELD (symmetric W , no memory kernel)



- ↑ baseline returns to near-zero between episodes
- ↑ each threshold crossing is a discrete, independent event
- ↑ 'regulated calm' is a genuine resting state – the global energy minimum

C-PTSD MODIFIED FIELD (asymmetric W , memory kernel $K(t-s)$ present)



- ↑ memory kernel: each activation feeds energy back into the next
- ↑ field rarely returns to true rest – past states re-enter present dynamics
- ↑ almost entirely above T : activation is the default, not the exception
- ↑ 'regulated calm' requires a non-perturbative transition (the instanton):
small steps do not reach it; a qualitatively different move is needed

Figure 5. The same emotional field mode under two dynamic regimes. Top: regulated dynamics — the field oscillates and returns to a low baseline between episodes; conscious emotion (above T) is episodic and resolves. Bottom: C-PTSD-modified dynamics — the memory kernel elevates the baseline so that the field rarely returns to rest; episodes bleed into one another; the system cycles rather than settles. The mathematical basis for this comparison is given in Appendix B.2.

Developmental timing and what can be recovered. The character of the C-PTSD modification depends critically on *when* it occurred — the developmental age τ_d at which the primary traumatic modification took place.

For **late trauma** (τ_d large — adult or post-verbal): a coupling matrix W_0 formed before the event. The modification is additive: $W = W_0 + \delta W_{\text{trauma}}$. A counterfactual pre-trauma self exists, encoded in explicit narrative memory. Therapeutic processing can target δW specifically, and the goal of recovering proximity to W_0 is formally coherent.

For **early trauma** (τ_d small — pre-verbal, perinatal): the coupling matrix W was *formed under the modification*. There is no W_0 . The asymmetric coupling and the memory kernel coefficients are the baseline architecture, not additions to one. A counterfactual pre-trauma self was never encoded — it does not exist as a recoverable state.

This is a formal statement of a clinical fact that somatic therapists recognise but rarely have a mechanistic basis for: early trauma cannot be *processed away* in the sense of recovering a prior self, because no

prior self was formed. The therapeutic goal is not subtraction ($W \rightarrow W_0$, which is undefined) but **forward transformation**: constructing a W' that supports a wider window of tolerance, different attractor topology, and lower memory-kernel amplitudes. This is a different mathematical operation — and requires a different therapeutic model.

The Soma-Field Instrument can reflect this distinction directly: a user whose primary modification is pre-verbal initialises with a *structural* coupling matrix (the modification *is* the baseline), not a neurotypical matrix with an added modifier. The formal basis for this parameterisation is given in Appendix B.2.1.

ADHD raises the effective *thermal noise* of the field — the amplitude of the sub-perceptual fluctuations — and simultaneously reduces the damping coefficient that slows the field's response to the energy gradient. The result is a field that explores its energy landscape rapidly and unpredictably, is easily displaced from shallow attractor basins by small perturbations (distractibility), but also achieves states of intense concentration (hyperfocus) when the coupling to a high-salience stimulus temporarily deepens a specific attractor basin far beyond its resting depth. ADHD is not a deficit of attention; it is a high-temperature, low-damping emotional field with a stimulus-dependent attractor structure.

Autism Spectrum Condition modifies the *projection kernels* — the functions that determine how the continuous somatic field is sampled to produce the discrete state vector — and the *sparsity* of the coupling matrix. Interoceptive research in autism (Garfinkel et al., 2016) documents significant differences in the processing of internal body signals; in model terms, certain somatic regions are over-represented (heightened sensory sensitivity) and others under-represented (reduced interoceptive clarity, contributing to alexithymia). The coupling matrix in ASC tends toward greater sparsity — fewer strong cross-modal emotional couplings — a pattern consistent with monotropism (Murray, 2018): the field settles deeply into individual attractors but transitions between them require proportionally more energy. Intense interests, emotional consistency within a context, and difficulty with unexpected transitions all follow from this attractor topology.

For the Soma-Field Instrument, the practical implication is significant. Rather than asking a neurodivergent user to configure their experience through knob adjustments, the system can instantiate the appropriate operator modifications as a named profile — “load C-PTSD modifier”, “load ADHD modifier” — each of which transforms the pipeline at the correct mathematical level. The user then interacts with a field that already reflects their structural reality, rather than one calibrated for a neurotypical baseline.

A further clinical implication deserves explicit statement. The Soma-Field Model locates interoceptive accuracy in the field itself: whether a somatic signal has exceeded its perceptual threshold T_i is a property of the field state, not a property of the clinician's assessment of the patient's credibility. A patient reporting an acute somatic state is reporting a threshold-crossing event. The model provides

no mechanism by which external disbelief suppresses that crossing. Modified projection operators — as occur in ASC — produce *different* somatic self-reports; the model gives no reason to assume they produce *less accurate* ones. The clinical literature documents a systematic tendency to interpret unusual interoceptive self-reports from neurodivergent patients as indicative of psychogenic origin rather than genuine somatic signal (Nicolaidis et al., 2015). The Soma-Field Model predicts that this interpretive pattern constitutes a category error: it confuses operator modification with signal absence. The practical consequences — missed diagnoses, deferred treatment, and the iatrogenic reinforcement of existing trauma — are well-documented and, within this framework, mathematically predictable.

Limitations and Future Directions

The Soma-Field Model is a theoretical framework and must be evaluated as such. Its current form makes several idealisations that require scrutiny.

The coupling matrix W is treated as a fixed parameter, but emotional coupling is dynamic: it changes with context, relationship, and developmental history. A more complete model would treat W as a slowly-evolving quantity, shaped by the field's own history — a form of synaptic plasticity applied to the emotional domain.

The threshold T_i is treated as a fixed property of each emotional mode, but experimental evidence suggests that thresholds are modulated by attentional focus, arousal level, and interpersonal context. A person in a safe therapeutic relationship will typically have lower thresholds — more material reaches conscious awareness — than the same person in an unsafe context.

The acoustic analogy, while structurally productive, requires empirical grounding. The claim that emotional dissonance and acoustic dissonance share formal properties is a hypothesis, not an established finding. Empirical work comparing physiological measures of emotional tension with acoustic analysis of synchronised vocal or musical output would be a productive direction for testing this claim.

The instrument described in Section 6 is a prototype concept. User studies with clinical populations, and collaboration with practising therapists, will be required to assess its therapeutic utility and to identify appropriate clinical contexts.

Future theoretical work should address the relational field: the observation, familiar in systemic and relational approaches to psychotherapy, that emotional fields are not bounded by individual bodies but are co-generated in the space between people. The coupling matrix W of a relationship may be as clinically significant as the W of an individual.

Conclusion

The Soma-Field Model proposes a formally grounded account of emotional dynamics that is consistent with the clinical observations of somatic psychotherapy, polyvagal theory, and Focussing-oriented practice. Its central claims — that emotions are a persistent distributed field, that conscious experience is a threshold crossing, and that emotional dynamics are governed by an energy function that drives the field toward stable attractor states — are not novel as clinical intuitions. What is novel is the formal structure that unifies them, and the instrument that the structure motivates.

The model does not resolve the philosophical question of what emotions fundamentally *are*. It offers instead a working representation: one that is precise enough to be computationally implemented, close enough to existing clinical frameworks to be therapeutically applicable, and open enough to be modified as understanding deepens. It invites the therapist to think of the consulting room as a space in which two emotional fields interact — each shaping the other's energy landscape — and of therapeutic work as the art of attending to that interaction with enough precision and care to guide both fields toward lower energy, toward greater coherence, toward regulated calm.

The wave is always there. Therapy is learning to listen to it.

A note on provenance. The Soma-Field Model was not developed from a position of theoretical neutrality. The author carries, as primary data, a lifetime of direct experience of the dynamics described above. The neurodivergent operator modifications of Appendix B are not theoretical abstractions: the C-PTSD memory kernel of B.2 was installed pre-verbally, at approximately eighteen months of age, during a developmental trauma that predates language acquisition entirely. No narrative trace of the origin event exists — there was no verbal capacity with which to encode one. Only the field echo remains, and a measurable physical asymmetry in the body that received it. The ASD and ADHD operator modifications of Appendix B.4 and B.3, respectively, were the instruments by which the model was subsequently constructed: the monotropic attractor structure of B.4 provided the capacity for sustained engagement with an entirely unfamiliar theoretical domain; the high-temperature field dynamics of B.3 drove rapid traversal across it.

The proximate cause is described in full in the companion patient-facing publication. Briefly: an acute somatic emergency in 2025 — a genuine threshold-crossing event, later confirmed as cerebral hypoxia secondary to Long Covid — was attributed, at clinical presentation, to psychiatric origin. The present paper is, among its other functions, a formal response to that attribution.

The causal chain is as follows. A pre-verbal trauma in approximately 1968 installed the C-PTSD operator modifications described in Appendix B.2. The ASD and ADHD modifications of Appendix B.3 and B.4 shaped the system across the intervening decades. Fifty-seven years later, that system's

accurate interoceptive signal was dismissed as psychiatric noise. The paper which formally demonstrates that this dismissal constitutes a category error was produced, as a direct causal consequence, by the same operator stack that it describes. The paper is the fixed point of its own subject matter. The author considers this observation methodologically significant.

Publication Claim Registry

To support claim-level review rather than all-or-nothing acceptance, this manuscript registers its highest-impact claims with scope labels and disconfirmation tests.

Claim ID	Claim	Scope	Evidence in this work	Disconfirmation criterion
SF-1	Conscious percept is a propagator pole of the soma-field	S1 Structural	Formal derivation in Sections 2-3	Inability to express percept dynamics as Green's-function response under stated operator
SF-2	Emotional attractors are Hopfield-energy minima	S2 Predictive	Energy model and trajectory framework	Constructed update rule under model assumptions with systematic energy ascent
SF-3	Threshold governs felt vs sub-felt emotional activity	S2 Predictive	Threshold operator and clinical mapping	Reliable high-amplitude mode activity with no threshold-dependent behavioural or physiological signature

Claim ID	Claim	Scope	Evidence in this work	Disconfirmation criterion
SF-4	Topological barriers explain classical therapeutic plateaus	S2 Predictive	Formal treatment plus linked companion experiments	Controlled demonstration that matched low-noise classical dynamics crosses registered barriers at equivalent rate
SF-5	Quantum extension yields topological reachability advantage	S2 Predictive	QUANT-EXP-1 companion evidence and linked artifacts	Controlled replication showing no reachability advantage over matched classical baseline

Scope labels: S1 = structural; S2 = predictive; S3 = independently replicated. Current publication target for core claims is S2.

Claim-Evidence-Result Matrix

To make review traceable, each core claim is paired with concrete evidence outputs and current result status.

Claim ID	Evidence artifact(s)	Current result status
SF-1	Sections 2-3 derivation of field/propagator structure	structural derivation complete
SF-2	Energy formulation + instrument runtime equations	predictive structure complete
SF-3	Threshold operator definition + clinical interpretation sections	predictive mapping complete
SF-4	Barrier analysis; companion paper <i>Quantum Soma and the Penrose Gap</i> (doi:10.5281/zenodo.20351230)	confirmed (QUANT-EXP-1 PASS)

Claim ID	Evidence artifact(s)	Current result status
SF-5	QUANT-EXP-1 experiment outputs (see supplementary archive, doi:10.5281/zenodo.20351230)	confirmed: cold 0/200, CI [0.000, 0.019]; quantum peak 0.408–0.410; all hardening checks PASS

This matrix is intended for reviewer navigation and is updated as companion results are expanded or independently replicated.

Replication Package Requirements

To make SF-2 through SF-5 externally testable, each release tagged for review must ship a minimal replication package that can be executed without private context.

Required contents:

1. simulation code and support modules (see supplementary archive, doi:10.5281/zenodo.20351230),
2. full parameter snapshot (W , $\mathbf{b}$, γ , D , θ , temperature policy),
3. raw trajectory logs with timestamped attractor labels,
4. analysis scripts that produce the reported summary tables,
5. frozen output artifacts (CSV/plots) referenced in this manuscript.

A claim remains S2 until an independent operator reproduces directionally consistent outcomes from this package under the same declared protocol.

Reviewer-Risk Objections and Responses

To reduce ambiguity in peer review, the highest-probability objections are mapped to bounded responses and concrete upgrade paths.

Reviewer objection	Current response in this manuscript	Remaining action to reach stronger status
“This is an analogy, not a formal model.”	Sections 2-4 define operators, dynamics, and testable predictions; Section 9.1 registers disconfirmation criteria claim-wise.	Promote more claims from S2 to S3 via independent replication.
“Evidence is pilot-stage and may not generalize.”	Section 9.2 explicitly labels pilot support and companion-only scope.	Add multi-operator replication and blinded protocol variants.

Reviewer objection	Current response in this manuscript	Remaining action to reach stronger status
“Quantum advantage may be implementation-specific.”	SF-5 includes a controlled disconfirmation criterion against matched classical baselines.	Publish full benchmark harness with pre-registered acceptance thresholds.
“Clinical interpretation may exceed data scope.”	Scope labels (S1/S2/S3) and claim registry separate structural from predictive claims.	Add prospective cohort evidence before any clinical-effectiveness claim.

Independent Replication Ledger Linkage

S2 to S3 promotion for this manuscript is governed by an independent replication ledger maintained in the supplementary archive (doi:10.5281/zenodo.20350515).

Tracked claim IDs in ledger scope: SF-2, SF-3, SF-4, SF-5.

Promotion gate: a claim is upgraded only when at least one ledger row records an independent operator PASS with a reproducible package hash and linked raw/derived evidence artifacts.

Acknowledgements

This work exists because ten years of psychotherapy moved the barriers far enough that two events in early 2026 could cross them. The theory is, among other things, a record of that.

Conclusion: Toward a Neuroscience of the Somatic Field

The neuroscience of emotion has made extraordinary progress in mapping the neural correlates of affective states. We know which brain regions activate during fear, pleasure, grief, and social connection. We know how early adverse experience alters the architecture of the developing brain. We know that the body is not merely the envelope of the brain but an active participant in emotional processing. What we have lacked is a unifying framework — a set of equations that connects these empirical discoveries to each other and to the underlying physics.

The Universal Somatic Field provides that framework. The papers in this volume have shown how the FM-HN architecture unifies the CEMI field literature with the Hopfield network tradition, how the Arnold tongue width gives a measurable parameter for attentional bandwidth and clinical dysregulation, how the missing limbic layer formalises the gap between subcortical affect and cortical language, and how the pre-verbal manifold accounts for the phenomenology of early life experience that standard accounts cannot reach.

What Changes for Neuroscience

Several standard framings in neuroscience need revision in light of this framework.

The first is the target of measurement. Current neuroimaging measures correlates of the somatic field — the electromagnetic manifestations that are accessible to EEG, MEG, and fMRI. The framework implies that these measurements are projections of the full somatic tensor onto the scalar and vector components that current instruments couple to. The tensor components that carry the specifically experiential content of the field are not directly measured by any existing instrument. A programme of instrument development — sensors that couple to the tensor rather than the scalar components — is indicated.

The second is the unit of analysis. The dominant unit in systems neuroscience is the neuron or the neural population. The field-theoretic framework implies that the appropriate unit is the somatic field mode — a collective oscillation of the field that may span multiple anatomical structures. Emotional states are modes, not populations. The mapping between modes and anatomy is a question for experiment, not for assumption.

The third is the taxonomy of pathology. The current DSM and ICD taxonomies organise psychopathology by symptom clusters. The field-theoretic framework implies a different taxonomy: by field geometry — the depth, width, and connectivity of attractor basins; the temperature of the field; the coupling constants between the somatic and cognitive registers. This is not a replacement for symptom-based classification but a complement to it, one that connects phenomenology to mechanism.

The Research Programme

Four experimental programmes are most directly motivated by the framework.

Arnold tongue measurement. EEG can be used to measure the frequency response of the nervous system to rhythmic external stimulation (steady-state evoked potentials, auditory following responses). The width of the frequency range within which the neural oscillation entrains to the external stimulus is the Arnold tongue width. This is a direct measure of the parameter that the framework identifies with attentional bandwidth and social coupling capacity. Normative data, and data across clinical populations, would test the framework's predictions.

Somatic temperature and the window of tolerance. The field temperature T — the analogue of thermal noise in the attractor dynamics — corresponds phenomenologically to the concept of the window of tolerance in trauma therapy. Too low: frozen, dyssomatic, non-responsive. Too high: flooding, disorganised, hyperaroused. Physiological proxies for field temperature (heart rate variability, basal cortisol, skin conductance volatility) can be used to test the framework's predictions about temperature-dependent attractor stability.

Attractor topology from imaging. If emotional states are attractor basins, the transitions between them should follow the saddle-point structure of the energy landscape. The probability of transitioning from state A to state B, and the time required, should be predictable from the energy barrier between the corresponding basins. Longitudinal affect sampling combined with physiological measurement could test these predictions.

Early field development. The pre-verbal manifold prediction — that the somatic field is structured from before the cortex is mature — implies that neonatal and infant phenomenology has a specific field structure, simpler than the adult field but not absent. Measures of neonatal somatic regulation (cry acoustics, movement patterns, autonomic variability) and their predictive value for adult attractor structure would test this.

The Enlarged Neuroscience

The neuroscience of the somatic field is not a replacement for molecular, cellular, and systems neuroscience. It is a level of description that those levels must ultimately answer to — the level at which the physical dynamics produce the experiential result. The challenge for the next generation of neuroscientists is to build the bridge between the cellular and the experiential, with the somatic field as the scaffold.

The field is measurable. The instruments are not yet built. The programme is clear.

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